# Prayer for the One Who Begins

**DRAFT — pending clergy/educator review**

Original text, not traditional liturgy. Wording lives in book/opening-prayer.txt.

*Hineni* — here I am.
I did not choose the road that brought me to this page,
but I choose to stand on it now.

I come not because I know, but because I want to know.
I come seeking *or*, light — not the whole of it,
only enough to read the next word.

There is no one among us who holds the whole truth.
We are all still learning the letters.
So I will not ask to be right.
I will ask to be honest,
to be patient with my own mistakes,
and to make a little more right in the world than I found —
*tikkun*, one letter at a time.

May these sounds, older than any of us,
become mine without ceasing to be ours.
May the voice I find in them be my own.
And when I read aloud with others,
may I feel what every learner before me felt:
not an outsider, but one more voice in the room.

*Baruch ha-ba* — blessed is the one who arrives.
Let us begin.

# The Priestly Blessing

Numbers 6:24–26. Your first page of Hebrew: fifteen words, thirteen different letters.

יְבָרֶכְךָ יְהוָה וְיִשְׁמְרֶךָ׃

יָאֵר יְהוָה פָּנָיו אֵלֶיךָ וִיחֻנֶּךָּ׃

יִשָּׂא יְהוָה פָּנָיו אֵלֶיךָ וְיָשֵׂם לְךָ שָׁלוֹם׃

PRAY_blessing_01
PLACEHOLDER

Source: data/corpus/registry.json (bless-priestly-1, bless-priestly-2, bless-priestly-3). Status: verified; **not proofread by a Hebrew educator**. The divine name is shown as written in the source; it is read aloud as “Adonai”.

# How to use this book and the app

Each letter has one page. Look at the picture and find the letter hiding in it. Trace the strokes in the order shown, say the sound, and read the three words. Then scan the code, or type the link, to open the same letter in the companion web app, where you can trace on a screen and hear it. Where a recorded voice is not available yet, the app falls back to your device's own Hebrew voice.

**The path:** the opening prayer and blessing → the alphabet and its 27 letter pages → the vowels → syllable practice → the prayers (every page has its own code) → survival Hebrew for travel and daily life. Read for the congregation first or for Israel first; both paths use the same letters.

**Print and cursive.** Every letter page shows the printed letter and the Israeli handwritten (ktav yad) form, each with numbered strokes where the data exists. Handwriting stroke data is marked as draft quality: it still needs a native writer's review.

**Which pronunciation?** Hebrew is read differently in Israel, in Sephardi tradition and in Ashkenazi tradition. The next page explains the differences. The app lets you choose; American synagogues often use the Sephardi values.

**Companion app.** The page for any letter is https://alef.example.org/#/letters/<letter> and any prayer is https://alef.example.org/#/read/<text>. **The host "alef.example.org" is a PLACEHOLDER: those links do not work until a real domain is chosen (one value, book/config.json).**

## Contents


The Priestly Blessing 2
Pronunciation traditions 4
The alphabet at a glance 6
The 27 letters (22 letters and 5 final forms) 7
Remember every letter 34
The vowels 39
Reading practice: syllables 41
Reading practice: words 42
The Priestly Blessing, word by word 44
Prayers and verses 45
Survival Hebrew 54
Index 66
Colophon, sources and statuses 67

# Pronunciation traditions

The same letters, three living ways of reading them aloud. **Israeli** is the everyday Modern Hebrew of Israel and the default of the Israel track. **Sephardi** is the liturgical tradition of Spanish-Portuguese and Mizrahi communities. **Ashkenazi** is the older Central and Eastern European liturgical tradition. The app's *congregation* setting picks one for the prayers. Data: data/pronunciation/*.json.

## Where they part

Bet is b with dagesh and v without.

Kaf is k with dagesh and kh (like loch) without.

Pe is p with dagesh and f without.

The dot decides: right dot = sh, left dot = s.

Dagesh kal hardens begadkefat letters (only bet, kaf, pe change sound in Israeli Hebrew). Dagesh chazak (doubling) is not pronounced in Modern Hebrew.

In General Israeli chet and khaf are one sound [χ]; older Mizrahi speakers keep the pharyngeal chet.

In General Israeli ayin is merged with alef. Pharyngeal ayin survives in Sephardi/Mizrahi tradition; Ashkenazi is silent.

Nearly all Israeli Jews pronounce resh as a uvular fricative; the English r is the typical American carry-over.

Ashkenazi tav without dagesh is s (Shabbos); Sephardi and Israeli tav is always t.

## Switching from Israeli/Sephardi to Ashkenazi

**Kamatz: a becomes o**: Where Israeli/Sephardi reads kamatz gadol as a, Ashkenazi reads it as o (aw). Patach stays a. בָּרוּךְ *Barukh / Bawrukh* (blessed); שָׁלוֹם *shalom / sholom* (peace)

**Cholam: o stays o, or becomes oy**: Choose one value for your community. Most American Ashkenazi readers use o; oy is the Polish/Galician/Chasidic value. אֲדֹנָי *Adonai / Adonoy* (my Lord (the divine name is read this way))

**Tzere: e becomes ei**: Ashkenazi tzere is a diphthong. Segol stays e. בֵּית *beit / beis* (house of); אֱלֹהֵינוּ *Eloheinu* (our God)

**Tav without dagesh: t becomes s**: Only tav WITHOUT a dagesh changes. A tav with dagesh is t in every tradition. שַׁבָּת *Shabbat / Shabbos* (Sabbath); יִתְגַּדַּל *Yitgadal / Yisgadal* (may it be magnified (Kaddish))

**Stress: last syllable becomes second-to-last**: Ashkenazi stress is historically penultimate (SHAB-bos, KID-dush). The sources do not say how consistently American prayer reading follows this; that part is inference. שַׁבָּת *shabBAT / SHABbos* (Sabbath)

# Same word, two traditions

| Hebrew | Meaning | Israeli | Ashkenazi | What switches |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| שַׁבָּת | Sabbath | Shabbat | Shabbos | tav, kamatz, stress |
| בְּרִית | covenant (brit milah) | brit | bris | tav, tzere |
| אֲדֹנָי | the divine name as read aloud | Adonai | Adonoy | kamatz, cholam |
| יִתְגַּדַּל | Kaddish, first word | Yitgadal | Yisgadal | tav |
| בַּת | daughter (bat mitzvah) | bat | bas | tav |
| אֱמֶת | truth | emet | emes | tav |
| חָתָן | groom | chatan | chosson | kamatz, tav, stress |
| בָּרוּךְ | blessed | Barukh | Bawrukh | kamatz |
| בֵּית | house of | beit | beis | tzere, tav |
| שָׁלוֹם | peace / hello | shalom | sholom | kamatz, stress |

## Sounding less like an outsider (Israeli Hebrew)

**Resh: back of the throat, not the English r.** Common slip: English [ɹ] ("rail") instead of the Israeli uvular [ʁ].
Try: Say kar, rishon, horim, rekhev slowly, keeping the tongue tip down behind the lower teeth.

**Five pure, short vowels: no glides.** Common slip: Diphthongised English vowels (sha-LOHM with an "oh-oo" glide).
Try: Say lo, bo, lu, li, la with no trailing w or y sound; clip them.

**Stress usually falls on the last syllable (milra).** Common slip: English-habit stress on the first or second syllable.
Try: Clap the syllables and land the clap on the last one.

**Silent shva makes consonant clusters.** Common slip: Inserting a short vowel in g-dola, k-tana, z-man.
Try: Say zman, then gdola, holding the two consonants together with no vowel between them.

**Do not carry shul pharyngeals into Israeli speech.** Common slip: Pharyngeal chet and ayin (the strict synagogue sound).
Try: Say chet as a throat-clearing kh, and read ayin as if it were alef.

**Less puff on p, t, k.** Common slip: Strongly aspirated English [$p^h$ $t^h$ $k^h$].
Try: Hold a hand in front of your mouth and say pita, toda, kafe with as little breath as you can.

Statuses and source links for each claim are in the data files; the drills are marked there as unreviewed by a native speaker.

# The alphabet at a glance

| # | Print | Cursive | Name | Sound | Page |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 01 | א |  | Alef | silent | 7 |
| 02 | ב |  | Bet / Vet | b / v | 8 |
| 03 | ג |  | Gimel | g | 9 |
| 04 | ד |  | Dalet | d | 10 |
| 05 | ה |  | He | h | 11 |
| 06 | ו |  | Vav | v | 12 |
| 07 | ז |  | Zayin | z | 13 |
| 08 | ח |  | Chet | kh, throat-clearing | 14 |
| 09 | ט |  | Tet | t | 15 |
| 10 | י |  | Yod | y | 16 |
| 11 | כ |  | Kaf / Khaf | k / kh | 17 |
| 12 | ל |  | Lamed | l | 18 |
| 13 | מ |  | Mem | m | 19 |
| 14 | נ |  | Nun | n | 20 |
| 15 | ס |  | Samekh | s | 21 |
| 16 | ע |  | Ayin | silent in Tel Aviv, throaty in Mizrahi speech | 22 |
| 17 | פ |  | Pe / Fe | p / f | 23 |
| 18 | צ |  | Tsadi | ts | 24 |
| 19 | ק |  | Kof | k | 25 |
| 20 | ר |  | Resh | r, Israeli uvular | 26 |
| 21 | ש |  | Shin / Sin | sh / s | 27 |
| 22 | ת |  | Tav | t | 28 |
| 23 | ך |  | Khaf sofit | kh (final) | 29 |
| 24 | ם |  | Mem sofit | m (final) | 30 |
| 25 | ן |  | Nun sofit | n (final) | 31 |
| 26 | ף |  | Fe sofit | f (final) | 32 |
| 27 | ץ |  | Tsadi sofit | ts (final) | 33 |

# Alef

silent

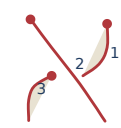
PRINT

א

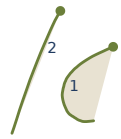
CURSIVE (KTAV YAD)

א

Gveret Levin (OFL font); stroke data below is draft




Print: 3 strokes




Cursive: 2 (draft)

L01_alef_print_mnemonic
PLACEHOLDER

**Find it:** Ox head. The letter's shape: two diagonal horns joined by a slanted body. (image: AI-image placeholder)

**Hear it & trace it:** https://alef.example.org/#/letters/alef

placeholder host, not a live site




אַבָּא

aba

dad

lessons:r07




אִמָּא

ima

mom

lessons:r09

אָז

az

so

phrasebook:fillers-01

**HOW IT SOUNDS** silent / a glottal stop between vowels (uh-oh). IPA Israeli [ʔ] or ∅. Ashkenazi: silent. Ashkenazi alef is silent at all times in most forms.

# Bet / Vet

b / v

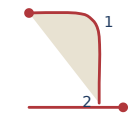
PRINT

ב

CURSIVE (KTAV YAD)

ק

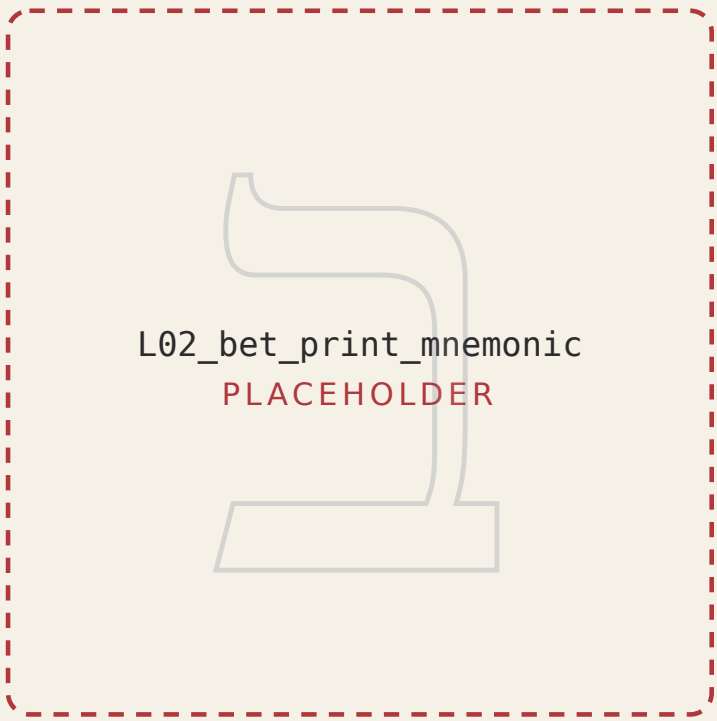
Gveret Levin (OFL font); stroke data below is draft




Print: 2 strokes




Cursive: 1 (draft)




**Find it:** Bed inside a house. The letter's shape: a box open to the left with a dot inside. (image: AI-image placeholder)

**Hear it & trace it:** https://alef.example.org/#/letters/bet

placeholder host, not a live site




בַּיִת

beit

house of

lessons:r08




בַּבַּיִת

babayit

in the house

lessons:r33

בֶּאֱמֶת

be'emet?

really?

phrasebook:fillers-06

**HOW IT SOUNDS** b with dagesh, v without (with dagesh: b as in boy; without dagesh: v as in very). IPA Israeli [b] with dagesh, [v] without. One of the three letters that still alternate in Modern Hebrew.

# Gimel

g

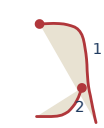
PRINT

ג

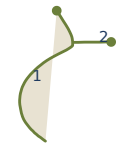
CURSIVE (KTAV YAD)

ג

Gveret Levin (OFL font); stroke data below is draft




Print: 2 strokes




Cursive: 2 (draft)

L03_gimel_print_mnemonic
PLACEHOLDER

**Find it:** Giraffe mid-stride. The letter's shape: a tall stroke with a short foot kicking out to the left. (image: AI-image placeholder)

**Hear it & trace it:** https://alef.example.org/#/letters/gimel
placeholder host, not a live site




גַּן
gan
garden
lessons:r18

גֶּשֶׁם
geshem
rain
lessons:il15

גָּדוֹל
gadol
big
lessons:r18

**HOW IT SOUNDS** hard g as in game, never soft. IPA Israeli [g]. No alternation in Modern Hebrew. Jewfaq: always a hard g.

# Dalet

d

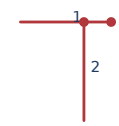
PRINT

ד

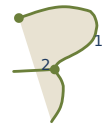
CURSIVE (KTAV YAD)

ד

Gveret Levin (OFL font); stroke data below is draft




Print: 2 strokes




Cursive: 2 (draft)

L04_dalet_print_mnemonic
PLACEHOLDER

**Find it:** Door frame. The letter's shape: a flat lintel with one post hanging from its right end. (image: AI-image placeholder)

**Hear it & trace it:** https://alef.example.org/#/letters/dalet
placeholder host, not a live site

דַּי

dai
enough / stop it
phrasebook:politeness-19

דֶּרֶךְ

derekh
way
lessons:r18

**HOW IT SOUNDS** d. IPA Israeli [d]. No alternation in Modern Hebrew.

# He

h

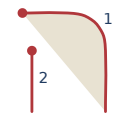
PRINT

ה

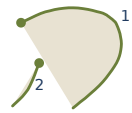
CURSIVE (KTAV YAD)

ה

Gveret Levin (OFL font); stroke data below is draft




Print: 2 strokes




Cursive: 2 (draft)

L05_he_print_mnemonic
PLACEHOLDER

**Find it:** House with an open window. The letter's shape: a lintel with a right post and a short detached left post leaving a gap at the top. (image: AI-image placeholder)

**Hear it & trace it:**
https://alef.example.org/#/letters/he

placeholder host, not a live site

L05_he_print_v2
PLACEHOLDER

הַיּוֹם

hayom
today
phrasebook:numbers-20

הֵי

hey
hi
phrasebook:greetings-02

הַזָּן

hazan
who feeds
lessons:r47

**HOW IT SOUNDS** h; silent at the end of a word unless it has mappiq. IPA Israeli [h]. Final he without mappiq is a vowel letter.

# Vav

v

PRINT

ו

CURSIVE (KTAV YAD)

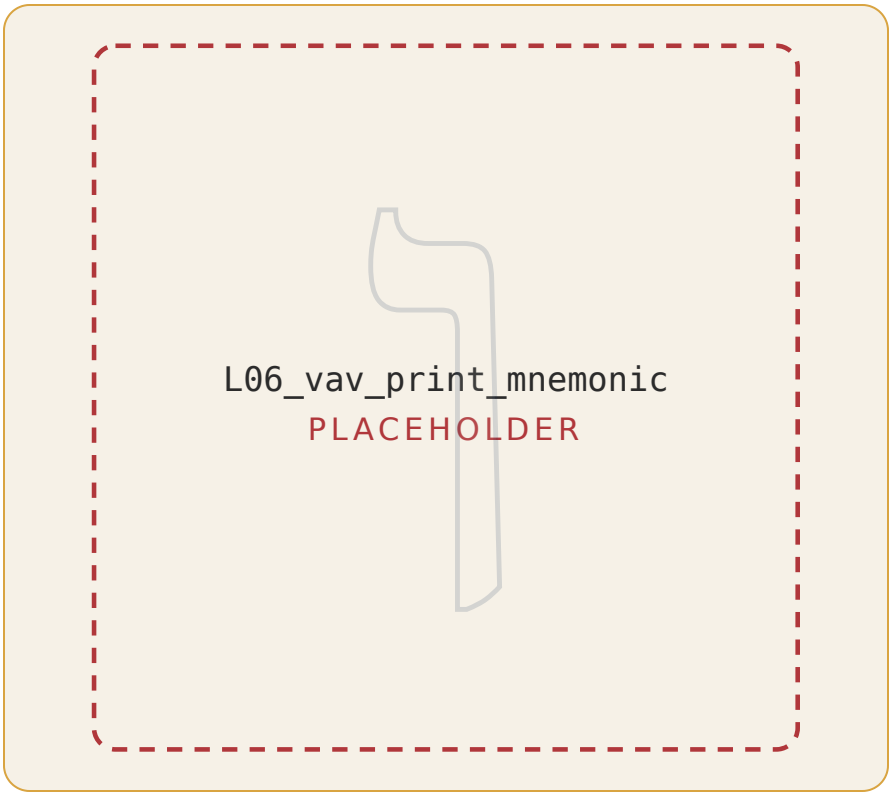
ו

Gveret Levin (OFL font); stroke data below is draft




Print: 1 stroke

Cursive: 1 (draft)




**Find it:** Vine on a stake. The letter's shape: one straight vertical with a tiny hook at top. (image: AI-image placeholder)

**Hear it & trace it:** https://alef.example.org/#/letters/vav

placeholder host, not a live site

וַואלָה

wallah

really? / wow / honestly

phrasebook:politeness-14

וְעַד

va'ed

and ever

lessons:r36

וְאַנִי

ve'ani

and I

lessons:r14

**HOW IT SOUNDS** v; also the vowel letter for o (cholam malei) and u (shuruk). IPA Israeli [v] (loanwords [w]). As a vowel letter see the cholam/shuruk records.

# Zayin

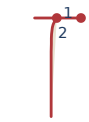
z

PRINT

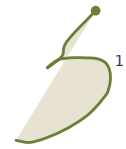
ז

CURSIVE (KTAV YAD)

Gveret Levin (OFL font); stroke data below is draft




Print: 2 strokes




Cursive: 1 (draft)

L07_zayin_print_mnemonic
PLACEHOLDER

**Find it:** Zipper pull. The letter's shape: a vertical with a small crossbar crown. (image: AI-image placeholder)

**Hear it & trace it:** https://alef.example.org/#/letters/zayin

placeholder host, not a live site

זָהָב

zahav
gold
lessons:r23

זֶה

zeh
this
lessons:r23

זוֹל

zol
cheap
lessons:il08

**HOW IT SOUNDS** z. IPA Israeli [z]. Check with a native speaker or phonetics reference. *(standard value; not in the fetched side-by-side table)*

# Chet

kh, throat-clearing

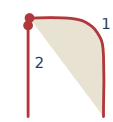
PRINT

ח

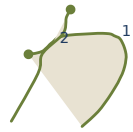
CURSIVE (KTAV YAD)

ח

Gveret Levin (OFL font); stroke data below is draft




Print: 2 strokes




Cursive: 2 (draft)

L08_chet_print_mnemonic
PLACEHOLDER

**Find it:** Hut doorway. The letter's shape: a gateway: two posts with a flat roof, no gap. (image: AI-image placeholder)

**Hear it & trace it:** https://alef.example.org/#/letters/chet
placeholder host, not a live site

ח�ֲצִי
chetsi
half
phrasebook:numbers-18

חָבֵר
chaver
friend
phrasebook:small-talk-18

חוּמוּס
humus
hummus
phrasebook:cafe-16

**HOW IT SOUNDS** ch as in Bach / loch (back-of-throat, no English chair sound). IPA Israeli [χ] (merged with khaf). General Israeli: chet and khaf merged into one sound. Older Mizrahi speakers keep the pharyngeal. Strict liturgical usage asks for the pharyngeal but it is rarely observed.

# Tet

t

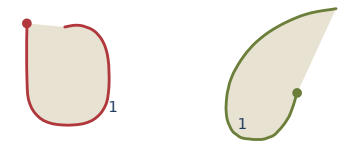
PRINT

ט

CURSIVE (KTAV YAD)

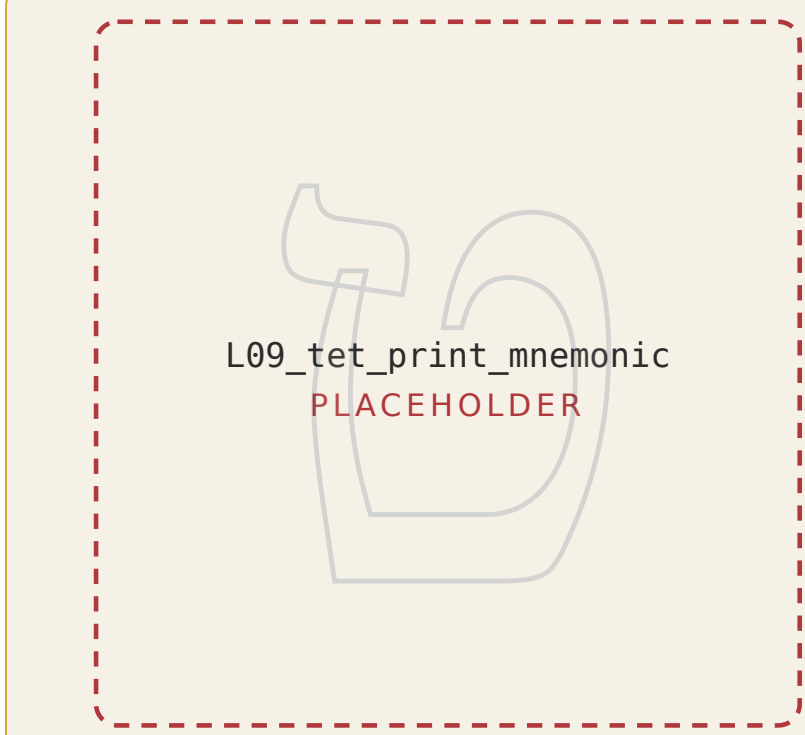
ט

Gveret Levin (OFL font); stroke data below is draft




Print: 1 stroke

Cursive: 1 (draft)




**Find it:** Teacup with a curled handle. The letter's shape: a bowl whose left rim curls inward. (image: AI-image placeholder)

**Hear it & trace it:** https://alef.example.org/#/letters/tet

placeholder host, not a live site




טוֹב

tov

OK / well / good

phrasebook:fillers-03




טֹבוּ

tovu

good are

lessons:r40

טַל

tal

dew

lessons:r23

**HOW IT SOUNDS** t. IPA Israeli [t]. General Israeli lost the emphatic sounds of Biblical Hebrew (Wikipedia). Which Sephardi/Mizrahi communities keep emphatic tet was not in our sources. *(standard value; not in the fetched side-by-side table)*

# Yod

y

PRINT

י

CURSIVE (KTAV YAD)

י

Gveret Levin (OFL font); stroke data below is draft




Print: 1 stroke




Cursive: 1 (draft)

L10_yod_print_mnemonic
PLACEHOLDER

**Find it:** Yo-yo on a short string. The letter's shape: a small comma hanging at the top of the line. (image: AI-image placeholder)

**Hear it & trace it:** https://alef.example.org/#/letters/yod
placeholder host, not a live site




יָמִינָה
yamina
right
phrasebook:directions-07




יֶלֶד
yeled
boy; child
lessons:il14

יַיִן
yayin
wine
phrasebook:cafe-12

**HOW IT SOUNDS** y as in yes; vowel letter for i/ei. IPA Israeli [j]. Check with a native speaker or phonetics reference. *(standard value; not in the fetched side-by-side table)*

# Kaf / Khaf

k / kh

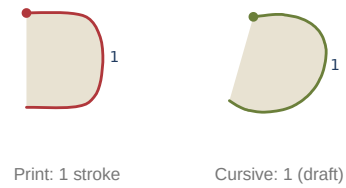
PRINT

כ

CURSIVE (KTAV YAD)

כ

Gveret Levin (OFL font); stroke data below is draft




Print: 1 stroke

Cursive: 1 (draft)

L11_kaf_print_mnemonic
PLACEHOLDER

**Find it:** Cupped palm. The letter's shape: a rounded bracket open to the left, like a cupped hand. (image: AI-image placeholder)

**Hear it & trace it:** https://alef.example.org/#/letters/kaf

placeholder host, not a live site

כֵּן
ken
yes
phrasebook:politeness-08

כְּלוֹמַר
klomar
that is / I mean
phrasebook:fillers-11

כִּי
ki
because
lessons:r10

**HOW IT SOUNDS** k with dagesh; kh (loch) without (with dagesh: k as in kite; without dagesh: kh as in loch). IPA Israeli [k] with dagesh, [χ] without. Khaf is the same sound as chet in General Israeli.

# Lamed

ל

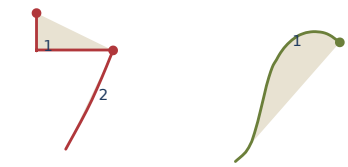
PRINT

ל

CURSIVE (KTAV YAD)

ר

Gveret Levin (OFL font); stroke data below is draft




Print: 2 strokes

Cursive: 1 (draft)

L12_lamed_print_mnemonic
PLACEHOLDER

**Find it:** Lighthouse / shepherd's staff. The letter's shape: the tallest letter, a staff rising above the line with a hooked foot. (image: AI-image placeholder)

**Hear it & trace it:** https://alef.example.org/#/letters/lamed
placeholder host, not a live site

L12_lamed_print_v1
PLACEHOLDER

לֶחֶם

lechem
bread
lessons:il07

L12_lamed_print_v2
PLACEHOLDER

לַיְלָה

laylah
night
lessons:il17

לֹא

lo
no
phrasebook:politeness-09

**HOW IT SOUNDS** l. IPA Israeli [l]. Check with a native speaker or phonetics reference. *(standard value; not in the fetched side-by-side table)*

# Mem

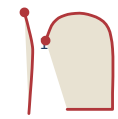
m

PRINT

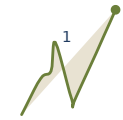
מ

CURSIVE (KTAV YAD)

Gveret Levin (OFL font); stroke data below is draft




Print: 2 strokes




Cursive: 1 (draft)

L13_mem_print_mnemonic
PLACEHOLDER

**Find it:** Mountain over water (mayim). The letter's shape: a square with a gap at bottom left and a wave-like top. (image: AI-image placeholder)

**Hear it & trace it:** https://alef.example.org/#/letters/mem
placeholder host, not a live site

L13_mem_print_v1
PLACEHOLDER

מַיִם
mayim
water
phrasebook:cafe-09

L13_mem_print_v2
PLACEHOLDER

מֶלֶךְ
melekh
king
lessons:r11

L13_mem_print_v3
PLACEHOLDER

מִשְׁפָּחָה
mishpachah
family
lessons:il14

**HOW IT SOUNDS** m. IPA Israeli [m]. Check with a native speaker or phonetics reference. *(standard value; not in the fetched side-by-side table)*

# Nun

n

PRINT

נ

CURSIVE (KTAV YAD)

נ

Gveret Levin (OFL font); stroke data below is draft




Print: 1 stroke

Cursive: 1 (draft)

L14_nun_print_mnemonic
PLACEHOLDER

**Find it:** Nail bent at the top. The letter's shape: a short bent stroke like a seed or a fish. (image: AI-image placeholder)

**Hear it & trace it:**
https://alef.example.org/#/letters/nun

placeholder host, not a live site




נְסִיעָה

nesi'ah

ride; trip

lessons:il10

נוּ

nu

well? / come on

phrasebook:fillers-02

נָכוֹן

nachon

right / correct

phrasebook:fillers-04

**HOW IT SOUNDS** n. IPA Israeli [n]. Check with a native speaker or phonetics reference. *(standard value; not in the fetched side-by-side table)*

# Samekh

S

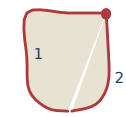
PRINT

ס

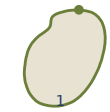
CURSIVE (KTAV YAD)

ס

Gveret Levin (OFL font); stroke data below is draft




Print: 2 strokes




Cursive: 1 (draft)

L15_samekh_print_mnemonic
PLACEHOLDER

**Find it:** Sun. The letter's shape: a closed round loop. (image: AI-image placeholder)

**Hear it & trace it:** https://alef.example.org/#/letters/samekh

placeholder host, not a live site

L15_samekh_print_v3
PLACEHOLDER

סָלָט

salat
salad
phrasebook:cafe-20

L15_samekh_print_v1
PLACEHOLDER

סֵפֶר

sefer
book
lessons:r20

L15_samekh_print_v1
PLACEHOLDER

סִדּוּר

sidur
prayer book
lessons:r51

**HOW IT SOUNDS** s. IPA Israeli [s]. Chabad notes Ashkenazim read an unaccented tav like samekh (see tav).

# Ayin

silent in Tel Aviv, throaty in Mizrahi speech

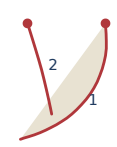
PRINT

ע

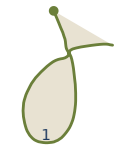
CURSIVE (KTAV YAD)

ע

Gveret Levin (OFL font); stroke data below is draft




Print: 2 strokes




Cursive: 1 (draft)

L16_ayin_print_mnemonic
PLACEHOLDER

**Find it:** Eye (ayin). The letter's shape: a Y with the left branch curling. (image: AI-image placeholder)

**Hear it & trace it:**
https://alef.example.org/#/letters/ayin

placeholder host, not a live site

עֶזְרָה
ezra!
help!
phrasebook:help-01

עֲשָׂרָה
asara
ten (10)
phrasebook:numbers-10

עֶשְׂרִים
esrim
twenty (20)
phrasebook:numbers-11

**HOW IT SOUNDS** silent / glottal stop; do not try a pharyngeal in Israel. IPA Israeli [ʔ] or ∅ (merged with alef). Ashkenazi: silent. General Israeli ayin is absorbed by alef. A pharyngeal learned in shul can mark a speaker as an outsider in Israel.

# Pe / Fe

p / f

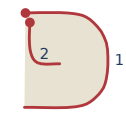
PRINT

פ

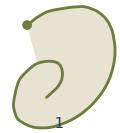
CURSIVE (KTAV YAD)

ﭫ

Gveret Levin (OFL font); stroke data below is draft




Print: 2 strokes




Cursive: 1 (draft)

L17_pe_print_mnemonic
PLACEHOLDER

**Find it:** Pie in an open mouth. The letter's shape: a coiled mouth with a tooth inside. (image: AI-image placeholder)

**Hear it & trace it:** https://alef.example.org/#/letters/pe

placeholder host, not a live site




פִּיתָה

pita

pita bread

phrasebook:cafe-19

פָּתוּחַ

patuach

open

phrasebook:shop-16

פָּלָאפֶל

falafel

falafel

phrasebook:cafe-17

**HOW IT SOUNDS** p with dagesh, f without (with dagesh: p as in pie; without dagesh: f as in fun). IPA Israeli [p] with dagesh, [f] without. Aspiration of p/t/k compared with English is unsourced (see drills).

# Tsadi

ts

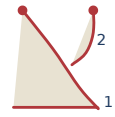
PRINT

צ

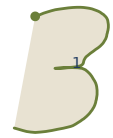
CURSIVE (KTAV YAD)



Gveret Levin (OFL font); stroke data below is draft




Print: 2 strokes




Cursive: 1 (draft)

L18_tsadi_print_mnemonic
PLACEHOLDER

**Find it:** Cat sitting (ts of 'cats'). The letter's shape: a kneeling figure, body leaning right with an arm reaching left. (image: AI-image placeholder)

**Hear it & trace it:** https://alef.example.org/#/letters/tsadi
placeholder host, not a live site

צֶדֶק
tzedek
justice
lessons:r24

צְדָקָה
tzedakah
charity; justice
lessons:r24

**HOW IT SOUNDS** ts / tz as in cats. IPA Israeli [ts].

# Kof

k

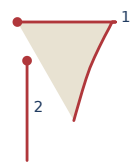
PRINT

ק

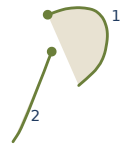
CURSIVE (KTAV YAD)

ק

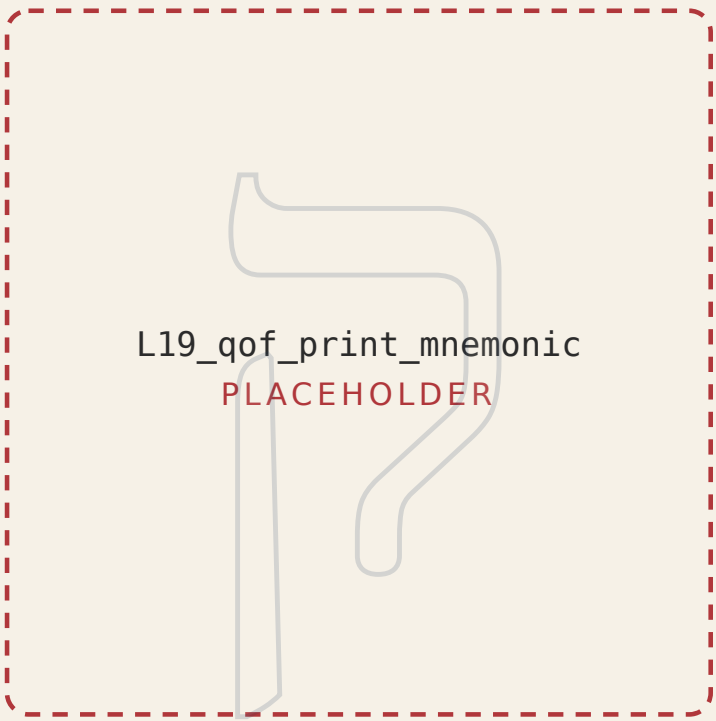
Gveret Levin (OFL font); stroke data below is draft




Print: 2 strokes




Cursive: 2 (draft)




**Find it:** Kangaroo tail / monkey (kof) hanging. The letter's shape: a rounded top with a long tail dropping below the line. (image: AI-image placeholder)

**Hear it & trace it:** https://alef.example.org/#/letters/qof

placeholder host, not a live site




קוֹל

kol

voice

lessons:r24




קָפֶה

kafeh

coffee

lessons:il06

קַר

kar

cold

lessons:il15

**HOW IT SOUNDS** k. IPA Israeli [k].

# Resh

r, Israeli uvular

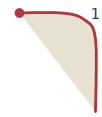
PRINT

ר

CURSIVE (KTAV YAD)

ר

Gveret Levin (OFL font); stroke data below is draft




Print: 1 stroke




Cursive: 1 (draft)

L20_resh_print_mnemonic
PLACEHOLDER

**Find it:** Rainbow arc / head (rosh). The letter's shape: a single rounded corner, like a bowed head. (image: AI-image placeholder)

**Hear it & trace it:**
https://alef.example.org/#/letters/resh
placeholder host, not a live site




רֹאשׁ

rosh
head
lessons:r09




רַכֶּבֶת

rakevet
train
lessons:il10

רֶגַע

rega
one moment
phrasebook:politeness-20

**HOW IT SOUNDS** back-of-the-throat r (like French or German r), not the English r. IPA Israeli [ʁ] uvular. Nearly all Israeli Jews use a uvular resh. Using the English [ɹ] is a leading outsider marker.

# Shin / Sin

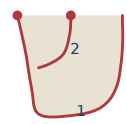
sh / s

PRINT

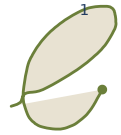
ש

CURSIVE (KTAV YAD)

Gveret Levin (OFL font); stroke data below is draft




Print: 2 strokes




Cursive: 1 (draft)

L21_shin_print_mnemonic
PLACEHOLDER

**Find it:** Shark teeth / three flames. The letter's shape: three prongs rising from a base. (image: AI-image placeholder)

**Hear it & trace it:** https://alef.example.org/#/letters/shin

placeholder host, not a live site

L21_shin_print_v1
PLACEHOLDER

שָׁלוֹם

shalom
hello / goodbye / peace
phrasebook:greetings-01

L21_shin_print_v2
PLACEHOLDER

שֶׁמֶשׁ

shemesh
sun
lessons:il15

שְׂמאלָה

smola
left
phrasebook:directions-06

**HOW IT SOUNDS** sh with the right dot, s with the left dot (with shin dot: sh as in shoe; with sin dot: s as in sun). IPA Israeli [ʃ] with right dot, [s] with left dot. Lithuanian Ashkenazi historically merged both as [s] (historical).

# Tav

t

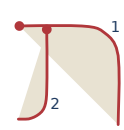
PRINT

ת

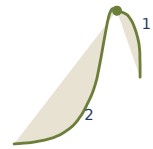
CURSIVE (KTAV YAD)

ת

Gveret Levin (OFL font); stroke data below is draft




Print: 2 strokes




Cursive: 2 (draft)

L22_tav_print_mnemonic
PLACEHOLDER

**Find it:** Table / tent. The letter's shape: a lintel on two legs, the left leg with a foot. (image: AI-image placeholder)

**Hear it & trace it:**
https://alef.example.org/#/letters/tav

placeholder host, not a live site




תּוֹדָה

toda

thank you

phrasebook:politeness-01




תּוֹרָה

torah

Torah

lessons:r38

תִּשְׁעָה

tish'a

nine (9)

phrasebook:numbers-09

**HOW IT SOUNDS** t (with dagesh: t; without dagesh: t). IPA Israeli [t]. Ashkenazi: s without dagesh (Shabbos), t with dagesh. The single most audible Ashkenazi/Sephardi switch (Yit-gadal vs Yis-gadal).

# Khaf sofit

kh (final)

PRINT

ך

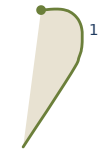
CURSIVE (KTAV YAD)

ך

Gveret Levin (OFL font); stroke data below is draft




Print: 1 stroke




Cursive: 1 (draft)

L23_kaf_final_print_mnemonic
PLACEHOLDER

**Find it:** Key hanging on a hook. The letter's shape: like kaf but the leg drops far below the line. (image: AI-image placeholder)

**Hear it & trace it:**
https://alef.example.org/#/letters/kaf-final
placeholder host, not a live site




מֶלֶךְ
melekh
king
lessons:r11




דֶּרֶךְ
derekh
way
lessons:r18




לַמֶּלֶךְ
lamelekh
to the king
lessons:r33

**HOW IT SOUNDS** kh as in loch (k with dagesh, as in the last word of the Priestly Blessing). IPA Israeli [χ] ([k] with dagesh). Same sounds as kaf; the Priestly Blessing ends one word with ךָ (dagesh) so it is read k. Words below end with this final form.

# Mem sofit

m (final)

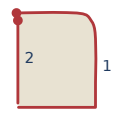
PRINT

ם

CURSIVE (KTAV YAD)

ם

Gveret Levin (OFL font); stroke data below is draft




Print: 2 strokes




Cursive: 1 (draft)

L24_mem_final_print_mnemonic
PLACEHOLDER

**Find it:** Sealed box. The letter's shape: a fully closed square. (image: AI-image placeholder)

**Hear it & trace it:** https://alef.example.org/#/letters/mem-final

placeholder host, not a live site




מַיִם

mayim
water
phrasebook:cafe-09




שָׁלוֹם

shalom
hello / goodbye / peace
phrasebook:greetings-01

הַיּוֹם

hayom
today
phrasebook:numbers-20

**HOW IT SOUNDS** m. IPA Israeli [m]. Same sound as the non-final form. Check with a native speaker or phonetics reference. *(standard value; not in the fetched side-by-side table)* Words below end with this final form.

# Nun sofit

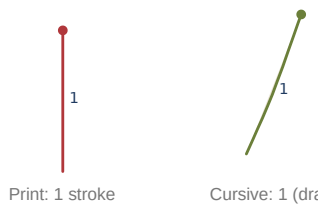
n (final)

PRINT

ן

CURSIVE (KTAV YAD)

Gveret Levin (OFL font); stroke data below is draft




Print: 1 stroke

Cursive: 1 (draft)

L25_nun_final_print_mnemonic

PLACEHOLDER

**Find it:** Nail driven down. The letter's shape: one long straight line dropping below the baseline. (image: AI-image placeholder)

**Hear it & trace it:** https://alef.example.org/#/letters/nun-final

placeholder host, not a live site




יַיִן

yayin

wine

phrasebook:cafe-12




בֵּן

ben

son

lessons:r12




גַּן

gan

garden

lessons:r18

**HOW IT SOUNDS** n. IPA Israeli [n]. Same sound as the non-final form. Check with a native speaker or phonetics reference. *(standard value; not in the fetched side-by-side table)* Words below end with this final form.

# Fe sofit

f (final)

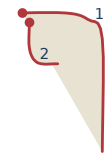
PRINT

ף

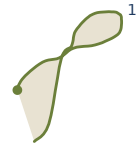
CURSIVE (KTAV YAD)

ף

Gveret Levin (OFL font); stroke data below is draft




Print: 2 strokes




Cursive: 1 (draft)

L26_pe_final_print_mnemonic
PLACEHOLDER

**Find it:** Flag on a pole. The letter's shape: pe with its tail dropping below the line. (image: AI-image placeholder)

**Hear it & trace it:**
https://alef.example.org/#/letters/pe-final

placeholder host, not a live site

אֶלֶף
elef
one thousand (1000)
phrasebook:numbers-15

עוֹדֵף
odef
change
lessons:il09

אַף
af
also; nose
lessons:r16

**HOW IT SOUNDS** f (p with dagesh). IPA Israeli [f] ([p] with dagesh). Same sound as the non-final form. Aspiration of p/t/k compared with English is unsourced (see drills). Words below end with this final form.

# Tsadi sofit

ts (final)

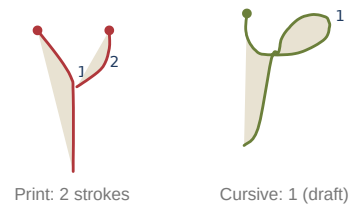
PRINT

ץ

CURSIVE (KTAV YAD)

ץ

Gveret Levin (OFL font); stroke data below is draft




Print: 2 strokes

Cursive: 1 (draft)

L27_tsadi_final_print_mnemonic

PLACEHOLDER

**Find it:** Tree with a taproot. The letter's shape: tsadi with a long straight descender. (image: AI-image placeholder)

**Hear it & trace it:** https://alef.example.org/#/letters/tsadi-final

placeholder host, not a live site




אֶרֶץ

eretz

land

lessons:r24

**HOW IT SOUNDS** ts / tz as in cats. IPA Israeli [ts]. Same sound as the non-final form. Words below end with this final form.

# Remember every letter

One card per letter: a shape to see, a sound to say, a silly story that holds both, the look-alike to watch out for, and a word to anchor it. The hook is the memory aid, not the history: the letter-name meanings are real Hebrew words, but the claim that each letter was originally drawn as that object is a popular teaching story. **Draft:** these hooks and the pointed anchor words have not been checked by a Hebrew teacher. The picture on each card is a labelled placeholder until the image run is done; the faint outlined letter is typeset over it as vector. The same 27 cards are on the cut-out flashcard sheets (alef-mnemonic-flashcards-*.pdf).




01

## Alef

א

**SHAPE**

A diagonal stroke with an arm reaching up on the right and a foot at the lower left, like an acrobat mid-handstand.

**SOUND**

silent letter that carries a vowel (like the tiny pause in 'uh-oh')

**STORY**

Alef is a mime doing a handstand: every move, zero noise. The vowel under it is the audience, doing all the clapping you can hear.

**LOOK-ALIKE**

Ayin is the other silent letter, but ayin is a curved cup with a diagonal lash and no crossing diagonal.

**ANCHOR WORD**

אַבָּא **aba** · dad




02

## Bet

ב

**SHAPE**

A house seen from the side: flat roof, back wall on the right, floor that sticks out past the wall, front door open on the left.

**SOUND**

b as in 'boy' with a dot inside (bet); v without the dot (vet)

**STORY**

Bet is a Bungalow with a Ball inside. The dot is the ball, so the house goes B. Take the ball out and it is Vacant: Vet, with a V.

**LOOK-ALIKE**

Kaf has soft round corners and no sticking-out floor. Bet has sharp corners and its floor pokes out at the back (right).

**ANCHOR WORD**

בַּיִת **bayit** · house




03

## Gimel

ג

**SHAPE**

An arched back on the right that runs down to a front leg, with a foot kicked out at the lower left.

**SOUND**

g as in 'go'

**STORY**

Gimel is a Grumpy camel on the Go: arched hump, and one foot kicked out ahead as he stomps toward the water.

**LOOK-ALIKE**

Nun is a bent line with a flat base and no kicked-out foot. Gimel has the foot sticking out at the bottom left.

**ANCHOR WORD**

גָּמָל **gamal** · camel




04

## Dalet

ד

**SHAPE**

A flat board across the top that overhangs on the right, held up by one post.

**SOUND**

d as in 'door'

**STORY**

Dalet is a Diving board on a Dock post: a flat plank that sticks out over the water, one post under it. Walk the plank and Dive: D!

**LOOK-ALIKE**

Resh has a rounded shoulder; dalet has a sharp corner and its board sticks out past the post. Final khaf looks like a resh with a long tail.

**ANCHOR WORD**

דֶּלֶת **delet** · door




05

## He (Hey)

ה

**SHAPE**

A roof and a right wall, with a short left wall that stops before the roof, leaving a gap.

**SOUND**

h as in 'hello' (a breath)

**STORY**

He is a Hut with a Hole in the wall. Lean out of the gap and Holler 'Hey!': the h is the breath that escapes through the hole.

**LOOK-ALIKE**

Chet is fully closed with no gap. Tav has its leg kicked out at the bottom left. He has a gap between the left leg and the roof.

**ANCHOR WORD**

הַר **har** · mountain




06

## Vav

ו

**SHAPE**

One plain straight stroke, as tall as the letters beside it, like a nail or a pole.

**SOUND**

v as in 'van'; also the vowels o and u when it carries them

**STORY**

Vav is a Vine hanging straight down from the line. Hum 'vvvv' like a vacuum cleaner. It also hooks the next word onto the last: that is why it means 'and'.

**LOOK-ALIKE**

Zayin has a bar on top. Yod is tiny and floats at the top. Final nun is much longer and drops below the line. Vav is a plain single stroke.

**ANCHOR WORD**

וֶרֶד **vered** · rose




07

## Zayin

ז

**SHAPE**

A short bar across the top and a straight stem down, like a dagger stabbed into the ground or a tiny T.

**SOUND**

z as in 'zoo'

**STORY**

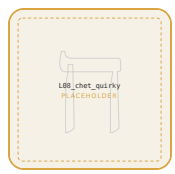
Zayin is a Zapper: a dagger with its guard on top, jabbed into the ground. Swish it and say Zzzap, like a zipper.

**LOOK-ALIKE**

Vav has no top bar. Final nun is much longer and has no bar. Zayin is short with a bar on the top.

**ANCHOR WORD**

זָהָב **zahav** · gold




08

## Chet

ח

**SHAPE**

A closed doorway: a roof joining a right leg and a left leg, with no gap.

**SOUND**

a rough throat 'h', like the ch in 'Chanukah' or Scottish 'loch'

**STORY**

Chet is a Closed gate with a cat behind it hissing at you: Chhhh! Say it the way you would say 'Chanukah' or 'challah', scraping from the throat.

**LOOK-ALIKE**

He has a gap in the left wall. Tav has a foot kicked out at the bottom left. Chet is closed all round.

**ANCHOR WORD**

חָלָב **chalav** · milk




09

## Tet

ט

**SHAPE**

A round-bottomed bowl with the right side curling in at the top, like a teapot with its spout bent inward.

**SOUND**

t as in 'top'

**STORY**

Tet is a Teapot with a round Tummy and its spout curled inward, full of Tea. Tov! (good): a Tummy full of Tea is Tov.

**LOOK-ALIKE**

Mem and samekh are boxy. Tav has straight legs. Tet is one round bowl with a curl at the top.

**ANCHOR WORD**

טוֹב **tov** · good




10

## Yod

י

**SHAPE**

The smallest letter: a tiny comma that floats at the top of the line.

**SOUND**

y as in 'yes'

**STORY**

Yod is a Yo-yo bead hanging at the top of the line, the tiniest letter with the loudest 'Yo!'. Yod for Yad (hand): a hand flicking a yo-yo.

**LOOK-ALIKE**

Vav is a tall straight stroke from the line to the top. Yod is short and floats near the top only.

**ANCHOR WORD**

יָד **yad** · hand




11

## Kaf

כ

**SHAPE**

A backwards C: a rounded shape with the opening on the left, like a cupped hand or a spoon bowl.

**SOUND**

k with a dot inside (kaf); kh like the letter chet, without the dot (khaf)

**STORY**

Kaf is a Kitchen spoon (kaf means spoon and palm!). With a dot, the Kernel is in the spoon: K. With no dot, it is empty and you breathe on it: Khhh.

**LOOK-ALIKE**

Bet has sharp corners and a floor that sticks out; kaf is soft and round. Final khaf has a long tail. Pe has a curl inside.

**ANCHOR WORD**

כֶּלֶב **kelev** · dog




12

## Lamed

ל

**SHAPE**

The only letter that rises above the line: a hook on top, then a bar and a diagonal leg.

**SOUND**

l as in 'lamp'

**STORY**

Lamed is a Lamp post with a bent arm that reaches high over the rest of the letters, Lighting the way so everyone can Learn.

**LOOK-ALIKE**

Nothing else rises above the line, so lamed is rarely confused with another letter.

**ANCHOR WORD**

לֶחֶם **lechem** · bread




13

## Mem

מ

**SHAPE**

A leaning left stroke and a box on the right whose bottom-left corner is open, like a tent with the door flap open.

**SOUND**

m as in 'mom'

**STORY**

Mem is a Mountain tent with its door flap open at the lower left, cosy and Mmm-warm inside. The final mem is the same tent zipped shut all round.

**LOOK-ALIKE**

Final mem is closed. Samekh is round and closed. Open mem has a gap at the bottom left.

**ANCHOR WORD**

מַיִם **mayim** · water




14

## Nun

נ

**SHAPE**

A bar on top, a stem on the right and a flat base going left: a figure kneeling and bowed over, facing right.

**SOUND**

n as in 'no'

**STORY**

Nun is a Nun kneeling in prayer, bent right over: the top is her bowed head, the stem her back, the base her flat shoes. N for Nun.

**LOOK-ALIKE**

Gimel has a foot kicked out at the bottom left; nun's base is flat. Kaf is rounder. Final nun is a plain long stick that drops below the line.

**ANCHOR WORD**

נֵר **ner** · candle




15

## Samekh

ס

**SHAPE**

A closed shape with soft rounded corners, like a ring or a cushion, sitting flat.

**SOUND**

s as in 'sun'

**STORY**

Samekh is a Soft cushion with rounded corners: you Sit on it and it Supports you. Sssss goes the air as you sink in.

**LOOK-ALIKE**

Final mem is a hard box with sharp corners; samekh is round all over. Open mem has a gap.

**ANCHOR WORD**

סֵפֶר **sefer** · book




16

## Ayin

ע

**SHAPE**

A curved cup on the right and a leaning stroke on the left, like a V-shaped eyelid with a lash.

**SOUND**

silent in most Israeli speech, like alef; a deep throat sound in some traditions

**STORY**

Ayin is an Eye winking silently: it sees everything and says nothing. All you hear is the vowel beneath, the same as alef.

**LOOK-ALIKE**

Tsadi has a flat base and a fork shape. Alef is the other silent letter but has a crossing diagonal. Ayin sweeps in one curve.

**ANCHOR WORD**

עַיִן **ayin** · eye




17

## Pe

פ

**SHAPE**

A rounded shape like kaf, with a curl tucked inside at the top left like a tongue behind the lips.

**SOUND**

p as in 'pop' with a dot inside (pe); f without the dot (fe)

**STORY**

Pe is a mouth pursed to Pop a bubble: with the dot it goes Pop, P! Without the dot the lips go loose and the air Fluffs out: Ffff, F.

**LOOK-ALIKE**

Kaf has no curl inside. Final fe has a long tail below the line. Pe has the curl tucked inside.

**ANCHOR WORD**

פֶּה **peh** · mouth




18

## Tsadi

צ

**SHAPE**

A Y-shaped fork on top that slants down into a flat base, like a kneeling person with raised arms.

**SOUND**

ts as in 'pizza'

**STORY**

Tsadi is a Tsetse fly with its wings up in a Y, perched on a slice of pizza: ts-ts-ts, the 'ts' of pizza, cats and nuts.

**LOOK-ALIKE**

Ayin has no flat base and sweeps in one curve. Final tsadi stands tall with a long stem. Tsadi's second stroke comes from the top right.

**ANCHOR WORD**

צִפּוֹר **tsipor** · bird




19

## Qof

ק

**SHAPE**

Like kaf with a long left leg that drops below the line.

**SOUND**

k as in 'kite' (same as kaf)

**STORY**

Qof is a Kooky monkey hanging down from a branch: the leg that dangles below the line is his tail. K for Kof, K for Kooky.

**LOOK-ALIKE**

Kaf stays on the line and has no leg below. Qof's leg hangs below the line.

**ANCHOR WORD**

קוֹף **kof** · monkey




20

## Resh

ר

**SHAPE**

A flat top and a smoothly curved right shoulder with no corner, like a head seen from the side.

**SOUND**

r (from the back of the throat in Israeli speech)

**STORY**

Resh is a Round head (rosh) from the side: a smooth shoulder with no corner. Rrrr, a growl from the back of the throat.

**LOOK-ALIKE**

Dalet has a sharp corner at top right and its bar sticks out. Resh is rounded. Final khaf is a resh with a very long tail.

**ANCHOR WORD**

רֹאשׁ **rosh** · head




21

## Shin

ש

**SHAPE**

Three prongs rising from a curved base, like three candle flames or a trident.

**SOUND**

sh as in 'shoe' with the dot on the right (shin); s as in 'sun' with the dot on the left (sin)

**STORY**

Shin is three flames on a birthday cake with a finger to the lips: Shhhh! The dot at the top right keeps it shh. A dot on the left makes it Sin: sinister means 'left'.

**LOOK-ALIKE**

Nothing common: only shin has three prongs. Tsadi is the closest in cursive.

**ANCHOR WORD**

שָׁלוֹם **shalom** · peace, hello




22

## Tav

ת

**SHAPE**

A roof with a right leg and a short left leg kicked out at the bottom, like he but with a foot.

**SOUND**

t as in 'top' (s in the Ashkenazi 'Shabbos')

**STORY**

Tav is a Table with a Toe: the right leg is straight, and the left leg has a toe tapping in thanks. Toda! (thank you)

**LOOK-ALIKE**

Chet is closed with no foot. He has a gap in the left wall. Tav has its foot at the bottom left.

**ANCHOR WORD**

תּוֹדָה **toda** · thank you




23

## Final Khaf

ך

**SHAPE**
A bar and a rounded shoulder with a long straight tail dropping below the line.

**SOUND**
kh (the chet sound), only at the end of a word

**STORY**
Final khaf is a King's cloak dragging on the floor behind him. The word ends and the cloak trails: melekh, with a throaty kh.

**LOOK-ALIKE**
Dalet and resh stay on the line. Final nun has no top bar. Final khaf has a bar, a rounded shoulder and a tail.

**ANCHOR WORD**

מֶלֶךְ **melekh** · king




24

## Final Mem

ם

**SHAPE**
A closed box with sharp corners.

**SOUND**
m, only at the end of a word

**STORY**
Final mem is the Mountain tent zipped shut: the word is over, nothing can get in. Yam, the sea outside, ends in a closed box.

**LOOK-ALIKE**
Samekh is a soft round ring. Open mem has a gap at the bottom left. Final mem is closed and square.

**ANCHOR WORD**

יָם **yam** · sea




25

## Final Nun

ן

**SHAPE**
One straight stroke that drops below the line, like a nail or a pole.

**SOUND**
n, only at the end of a word

**STORY**
Final nun is the Nun standing up straight at last, her long coat reaching below the line. Gan, a garden, ends in a straight pole.

**LOOK-ALIKE**
Vav is shorter and stays on the line. Final khaf has a bar and a shoulder. Final nun is a plain long stick.

**ANCHOR WORD**

גַּן **gan** · garden, kindergarten




26

## Final Fe

ף

**SHAPE**
The pe shape with its curl inside and a long right stem that drops below the line.

**SOUND**
f, only at the end of a word

**STORY**
Final fe is a mouth with the tongue lolling out below the line to blow Fffff at the end of the word, the way you blow a feather off a spoon (kaf).

**LOOK-ALIKE**
Final tsadi forks like a Y on top; final fe has the curl and a round top. Pe stays on the line.

**ANCHOR WORD**

כַּף **kaf** · spoon, palm




27

## Final Tsadi

ץ

**SHAPE**
A Y-shaped fork on top and one long straight stem dropping below the line.

**SOUND**
ts, only at the end of a word

**STORY**
Final tsadi is a Tree: Y-shaped branches on top and a long trunk down into the land (eretz). The tree rustles ts at the end of the word.

**LOOK-ALIKE**
Final fe has a round top and a curl. Final nun has no fork. Final tsadi forks like a Y.

**ANCHOR WORD**

אֶרֶץ **eretz** · land, country

# The vowels and marks

Hebrew vowels are dots and dashes around the letter, shown here on a bet (or a vav for the two vav-vowels). Modern Israeli Hebrew has five vowel sounds, so several signs share one sound; the traditions differ more. From data/pronunciation/niqqud.json.



## Kamatz (kamatz gadol) קָמָץ

below (T-shaped mark under the letter)

Example: אָב father

**Israeli** [a] a as in father (short, no glide)
**Sephardi** [a(ː)] a as in father
**Ashkenazi** [ɔ] aw as in saw (Barukh -> Bawrukh)

**Variants:** בָה kamatz + silent he (or alef); same sound as kamatz · בָ Has its own Unicode glyph U+05C7 but most print uses the ordinary kamatz.

In Ashkenazi the alternative values are [u] in open syllables (southern dialects) and [ʌ] (Lithuanian). *(English approximation not source-verified)*



## Patach פַּתַח

below (horizontal line)

Example: בַּיִת house (bayit)

**Israeli** [a] a as in father
**Sephardi** [a] a as in father
**Ashkenazi** [a] a as in father

A patach under a final ע ,ח or ה-with-mappiq is a furtive patach and is read BEFORE the letter (נַח = [no.ax]). *(English approximation not source-verified)*



## Tzere צֵירֵי

below (two horizontal dots)

Example: בֵּן son (ben)

**Israeli** [ę] e as in bed (a few words and speakers say ei as in they)
**Sephardi** [e(ː)] e as in bed
**Ashkenazi** [ej] ei as in they (Polish usage is often like eye)

**Variants:** בֵי tzere + yod; commonly romanised ei

Pealim: Israeli tzere may be [ei] in some cases, not for all speakers. Ashkenazi [aj] is the Polish variant. *(English approximation not source-verified)*



## Segol סֶגוֹל

below (three dots in a triangle)

Example: סֵפֶר book (sefer)

**Israeli** [ę] e as in bed
**Sephardi** [e] e as in bed
**Ashkenazi** [e] e as in bed (stressed syllables in Polish/Ukrainian usage: ei)

Israeli tzere and segol sound the same; the sign distinction survives only in the spelling. *(English approximation not source-verified)*



## Chirik חִירִיק

below (single dot)

Example: אִמָּא mother (ima)

**Israeli** [i] i as in machine (short)
**Sephardi** [i] i as in machine
**Ashkenazi** [i] i as in machine

**Variants:** בִי chirik + yod; same sound

Israeli writing usually adds a yod (chirik malei) to disambiguate; same sound. *(English approximation not source-verified)*



## Cholam חוֹלָם

above-left of the letter (chaser) or over a vav (malei)

Example: שָׁלוֹם peace (shalom)

**Israeli** [o] o as in for (no glide)
**Sephardi** [o(ː)] o as in home
**Ashkenazi** [o] o as in home (southern German / many American Ashkenazim); oy as in oy vey (Polish/Galician, Chasidic); ow (northern German)

**Variants:** בֹ cholam without vav: the dot sits above-left of the letter · בוֹ cholam on a vav (vav is a vowel letter here); same sound

Ashkenazi values by sub-dialect: [oj] Polish/Galician, [au] N. German, [ej] Lithuanian, [øi] Hungarian, [o] S. German. *(English approximation not source-verified)*



## Kubutz קֻבּוּץ

below (three diagonal dots)

Example: סֻכָּה sukkah (booth)

**Israeli** [u] oo as in boot (short)
**Sephardi** [u] oo as in boot
**Ashkenazi** [u] oo as in boot; occasionally as in put

Hungarian/Oberlander Ashkenazi [y]; occasional [ʊ]. Same sound as shuruk. *(English approximation not source-verified)*



## Shuruk שׁוּרוּק

a dot inside a vav (the vav is a vowel letter)

Example: סוּס horse (sus)

**Israeli** [u] oo as in boot
**Sephardi** [u] oo as in boot
**Ashkenazi** [u] oo as in boot

The shared id is shuruk; the shape is a vav with a dagesh dot (U+05D5 U+05BC) after a consonant. *(English approximation not source-verified)*

## Shva שְׁוָא



below (two vertical dots)

Example: שְׁמַע hear (Shema)

**Israeli** [ę] or ∅ (no vowel) e as in begin, or silent
**Sephardi** [ɛ]~[ę] when vocal, ∅ when silent e as in bed when vocal; silent otherwise
**Ashkenazi** ∅ colloquially (zman); [e]/[ə] when read strictly in liturgy often dropped (zman); short uh/e when read strictly in prayer

js. Modern Israelis often drop or insert the [e] on phonological grounds, not by the historical rules; no corpus measurement was found. *(English approximation not source-verified)*

## Chataf patach חֲטַף פַּתַח



below (shva + patach)

Example: חֲבֵרָה company / female friend (chavera)

**Israeli** [a] very short a as in father
**Sephardi** [a] very short a
**Ashkenazi** [a] very short a

Reduced vowels appear mostly under guttural letters. *(English approximation not source-verified)*

## Chataf segol חֲטַף סֶגוֹל



below (shva + segol)

Example: אֱמֶת truth (emet)

**Israeli** [ę] very short e as in bed
**Sephardi** [e] very short e
**Ashkenazi** [e] very short e

Short reduced e. *(English approximation not source-verified)*

## Chataf kamatz חֲטַף קָמָץ



below (shva + kamatz)

Example: צָהֳרַיִם noon (tsohorayim)

**Israeli** [ǫ] very short o as in for
**Sephardi** [ɔ] very short o
**Ashkenazi** [ɔ] very short aw/o

Not to be confused with kamatz katan. *(English approximation not source-verified)*

## Dagesh דָּגֵשׁ



inside the letter (a dot)

Example: שַׁבָּת Shabbat

**Israeli** hardens bet/kaf/pe to [b][k][p]; gemination absent no sound of its own; makes b, k, p instead of v, kh, f
**Sephardi** hardens bet/kaf/pe to [b][k][p]; (gemination not covered by the sources fetched) same
**Ashkenazi** hardens bet/kaf/pe to [b][k][p]; (gemination not covered by the sources fetched) same; also makes tav t instead of s

**Variants:** בּ hardens begadkefat letters (bet, gimel, dalet, kaf, pe, tav); only bet/kaf/pe change sound in Israeli Hebrew · שּׁ doubling; not heard in Israeli Hebrew · הּ dagesh in a final he: the he is a real [h]

Two things share one sign: dagesh kal (begadkefat hardening) and dagesh chazak (doubling). *(English approximation not source-verified)*

## Shin dot נקודת שין



above the right branch of the letter

Example: שָׁלוֹם peace (shalom)

**Israeli** [ʃ] sh as in shoe
**Sephardi** [ʃ] sh as in shoe
**Ashkenazi** [ʃ] sh as in shoe

The dot is written over the right (first) branch. *(English approximation not source-verified)*

## Sin dot נקודת שין שמאלית



above the left (third) branch of the letter

Example: יִשְׂרָאֵל Israel (Yisrael)

**Israeli** [s] s as in sun
**Sephardi** [s] s as in sun
**Ashkenazi** [s] s as in sun

Lithuanian Ashkenazi historically merged shin and sin as [s] (historical, not current). *(English approximation not source-verified)*

# Reading practice: syllables

Say each syllable aloud. Rows are consonants, columns are vowel signs (Israeli values).

| | אַ | אָ | אֵ | אֶ | אִ | אֹ | אֻ |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| **m** | מַ<br>ma | מָ<br>ma | מֵ<br>me | מֶ<br>me | מִ<br>mi | מֹ<br>mo | מֻ<br>mu |
| **l** | לַ<br>la | לָ<br>la | לֵ<br>le | לֶ<br>le | לִ<br>li | לֹ<br>lo | לֻ<br>lu |
| **sh** | שַׁ<br>sha | שָׁ<br>sha | שֵׁ<br>she | שֶׁ<br>she | שִׁ<br>shi | שֹׁ<br>sho | שֻׁ<br>shu |
| **r** | רַ<br>ra | רָ<br>ra | רֵ<br>re | רֶ<br>re | רִ<br>ri | רֹ<br>ro | רֻ<br>ru |
| **b** | בַּ<br>ba | בָּ<br>ba | בֵּ<br>be | בֶּ<br>be | בִּ<br>bi | בֹּ<br>bo | בֻּ<br>bu |
| **d** | דַ<br>da | דָ<br>da | דֵ<br>de | דֶ<br>de | דִ<br>di | דֹ<br>do | דֻ<br>du |

Generated from code points only.

# Reading practice: words

72 short words from the reading-track lessons (data/curriculum/lessons.json), in lesson order, so the first ones use only the letters and vowels taught first. Transliteration comes from the phrasebook where it has the word; entries marked * are machine-generated by the app's transliterator (Israeli, siddur style) and have not been checked by a native speaker.

| | | | |
|---|---|---|---|
| שָׁב<br>**shav***<br>he returned | שַׁבָּת<br>**shabat***<br>Sabbath | בַּת<br>**bat***<br>daughter | שָׁלוֹם<br>**shalom**<br>peace; hello |
| לוֹ<br>**lo***<br>to him | בִּי<br>**bi***<br>in me | לִי<br>**li***<br>to me | אַבָּא<br>**aba***<br>dad |
| בָּא<br>**ba***<br>he came | הָיָה<br>**hayah***<br>he was | לֹא<br>**lo**<br>no; not | אֵל<br>**el***<br>God |
| בֵּית<br>**beit***<br>house of | לֵב<br>**lev***<br>heart | שִׁיר<br>**shir***<br>song | אִמָּא<br>**ima***<br>mom |
| רֹאשׁ<br>**rosh***<br>head | רָם<br>**ram***<br>high | כִּי<br>**ki***<br>because | לָךְ<br>**lakh***<br>to you |
| אַתָּה<br>**atah***<br>you (m.) | אֶת<br>**et***<br>(object marker) | מֶלֶךְ<br>**melekh***<br>king | בֵּן<br>**ben***<br>son |
| שָׁנָה<br>**shanah***<br>year | אֲנִי<br>**ani***<br>I | אָמֵן<br>**amen***<br>amen | שׁוּב<br>**shuv***<br>again; return! |
| כֻּלָּם<br>**kulam***<br>all of them | בְּרָכָה<br>**berakhah***<br>blessing | לְךָ<br>**lekha***<br>to you | וַאֲנִי<br>**ve'ani***<br>and I |
| יְהוָה<br>**adonai***<br>the Name (read aloud as Adonai) | פֶּה<br>**peh***<br>mouth | אַף<br>**af***<br>also; nose | פָּנָיו<br>**panav***<br>His face |

| | | | |
|---|---|---|---|
| חַי<br>**chai***<br>alive | חָכָם<br>**chakham***<br>wise | רוּחַ<br>**rucha***<br>spirit; wind | אֶחָד<br>**echad**<br>one |
| גָּדוֹל<br>**gadol***<br>big | גַּן<br>**gan***<br>garden | דֶּרֶךְ<br>**derekh***<br>way | שְׁמַע<br>**shema***<br>hear! |
| עַם<br>**am***<br>people | עוֹלָם<br>**olam***<br>world; forever | סֵפֶר<br>**sefer***<br>book | שִׂמְחָה<br>**simchah***<br>joy |
| אֱלֹהִים<br>**elohim***<br>God | אֱמֶת<br>**emet***<br>truth | אֲנִי<br>**ani***<br>I | אֲדֹנָי<br>**adonai***<br>my Lord (read in place of the Name) |
| אֳנִיָּה<br>**oniyah***<br>ship | זֶה<br>**zeh***<br>this | טוֹב<br>**tov**<br>good | זָהָב<br>**zahav***<br>gold |
| טַל<br>**tal***<br>dew | צֶדֶק<br>**tzedek***<br>justice | אֶרֶץ<br>**eretz***<br>land | קוֹל<br>**kol***<br>voice |
| קָדוֹשׁ<br>**kadosh***<br>holy | צְדָקָה<br>**tzedakah***<br>charity; justice | יָאֵר<br>**ya'er***<br>may He shine | אֵלֶיךָ<br>**elekha***<br>toward you |
| יִשָּׂא<br>**yisa***<br>may He lift | וְיָשֵׂם<br>**veyasem***<br>and grant | בָּרוּךְ<br>**barukh***<br>blessed | הָעוֹלָם<br>**ha'olam***<br>the world |
| מִשְׁפָּט<br>**mishpat***<br>justice | וּבְכָל<br>**uvekhal***<br>and with all | כָּתַב<br>**katav***<br>he wrote | שְׁמֵהּ<br>**shemeh***<br>His name (Aramaic) |

## The Priestly Blessing, word by word

| Hebrew | Modern Israeli | Literal |
|---|---|---|
| יְבָרֶכְךָ | yevarekh'kha | may-he-bless-you |
| וְיִשְׁמְרֶךָ | veyishmerekha | and-may-he-keep-you |
| יָאֵר | ya'er | may-he-shine |
| פָּנָיו | panav | his-face |
| אֵלֶיךָ | elekha | toward-you |
| וִיחֻנֶּךָּ | vichuneka | and-may-he-be-gracious-to-you |
| יִשָּׂא | yisa | may-he-lift |
| וְיָשֵׂם | veyasem | and-may-he-set |
| לְךָ | lekha | for-you |
| שָׁלוֹם | shalom | peace |

The divine name (three occurrences, spoken “Adonai”) is omitted from this table. Words and glosses come from a research note and are **not yet verified by a Hebrew teacher**.

# Prayers and verses

27 texts from data/corpus/registry.json, each with its own code. Every text matches its cited source by machine comparison; **none has been proofread by a Hebrew educator**. The divine name appears as written in the sources and is read “Adonai”. Some texts overlap (the Shema appears alone, within the V’ahavta and in the combined reading).

## Priestly Blessing, line 1 Numbers 6:24

יְבָרֶכְךָ יְהוָה וְיִשְׁמְרֶךָ׃

The LORD bless thee, and keep thee;

**Hebrew:** Unicode/XML Leningrad Codex (UXLC) UXLC 2.6 (file dated 19 Oct 2026) · licence: Public Domain / copy without restriction (tanach.us/License.html). **English:** JPS 1917 (The Holy Scriptures: A New Translation) (Public Domain). Status: verified · **not proofread** · https://alef.example.org/#/read/bless-priestly-1

## Priestly Blessing, line 2 Numbers 6:25

יָאֵר יְהוָה פָּנָיו אֵלֶיךָ וִיחֻנֶּךָּ׃

The LORD make His face to shine upon thee, and be gracious unto thee;

**Hebrew:** Unicode/XML Leningrad Codex (UXLC) UXLC 2.6 (file dated 19 Oct 2026) · licence: Public Domain / copy without restriction (tanach.us/License.html). **English:** JPS 1917 (The Holy Scriptures: A New Translation) (Public Domain). Status: verified · **not proofread** · https://alef.example.org/#/read/bless-priestly-2

## Priestly Blessing, line 3 Numbers 6:26

יִשָּׂא יְהוָה פָּנָיו אֵלֶיךָ וְיָשֵׂם לְךָ שָׁלוֹם׃

The LORD lift up His countenance upon thee, and give thee peace.

**Hebrew:** Unicode/XML Leningrad Codex (UXLC) UXLC 2.6 (file dated 19 Oct 2026) · licence: Public Domain / copy without restriction (tanach.us/License.html). **English:** JPS 1917 (The Holy Scriptures: A New Translation) (Public Domain). Status: verified · **not proofread** · https://alef.example.org/#/read/bless-priestly-3

## Shema Yisrael Deuteronomy 6:4

שְׁמַע יִשְׂרָאֵל יְהוָה אֱלֹהֵינוּ יְהוָה אֶחָד׃

HEAR, O ISRAEL: THE LORD OUR GOD, THE LORD IS ONE.

**Hebrew:** Unicode/XML Leningrad Codex (UXLC) UXLC 2.6 (file dated 19 Oct 2026) · licence: Public Domain / copy without restriction (tanach.us/License.html). **English:** JPS 1917 (The Holy Scriptures: A New Translation) (Public Domain). Status: verified · **not proofread** · https://alef.example.org/#/read/shema-1

## V'ahavta, verse 1 Deuteronomy 6:5

וְאָהַבְתָּ אֵת יְהוָה אֱלֹהֶיךָ בְּכָל־לְבָבְךָ וּבְכָל־נַפְשְׁךָ וּבְכָל־מְאֹדֶךָ׃

And thou shalt love the LORD thy God with all thy heart, and with all thy soul, and with all thy might.

**Hebrew:** Unicode/XML Leningrad Codex (UXLC) UXLC 2.6 (file dated 19 Oct 2026) · licence: Public Domain / copy without restriction (tanach.us/License.html). **English:** JPS 1917 (The Holy Scriptures: A New Translation) (Public Domain). Status: verified · **not proofread** · https://alef.example.org/#/read/vahavta-1

## V'ahavta, verses 2-3 Deuteronomy 6:6-7

וְהָיוּ הַדְּבָרִים הָאֵלֶּה אֲשֶׁר אָנֹכִי מְצַוְּךָ הַיּוֹם עַל־לְבָבֶךָ׃

וְשִׁנַּנְתָּם לְבָנֶיךָ וְדִבַּרְתָּ בָּם בְּשִׁבְתְּךָ בְּבֵיתֶךָ וּבְלֶכְתְּךָ בַדֶּרֶךְ וּבְשָׁכְבְּךָ וּבְקוּמֶךָ׃

And these words, which I command thee this day, shall be upon thy heart; and thou shalt teach them diligently unto thy children, and shalt talk of them when thou sittest in thy house, and when thou walkest by the way, and when thou liest down, and when thou risest up.

**Hebrew:** Unicode/XML Leningrad Codex (UXLC) UXLC 2.6 (file dated 19 Oct 2026) · licence: Public Domain / copy without restriction (tanach.us/License.html). **English:** JPS 1917 (The Holy Scriptures: A New Translation) (Public Domain). Status: verified · **not proofread** · https://alef.example.org/#/read/vahavta-2

## V'ahavta Deuteronomy 6:5-9

וְאָהַבְתָּ אֵת יְהוָה אֱלֹהֶיךָ בְּכָל־לְבָבְךָ וּבְכָל־נַפְשְׁךָ וּבְכָל־מְאֹדֶךָ׃

וְהָיוּ הַדְּבָרִים הָאֵלֶּה אֲשֶׁר אָנֹכִי מְצַוְּךָ הַיּוֹם עַל־לְבָבֶךָ׃

וְשִׁנַּנְתָּם לְבָנֶיךָ וְדִבַּרְתָּ בָּם בְּשִׁבְתְּךָ בְּבֵיתֶךָ וּבְלֶכְתְּךָ בַדֶּרֶךְ וּבְשָׁכְבְּךָ וּבְקוּמֶךָ׃

וּקְשַׁרְתָּם לְאוֹת עַל־יָדֶךָ וְהָיוּ לְטֹטָפֹת בֵּין עֵינֶיךָ׃

וּכְתַבְתָּם עַל־מְזוּזוֹת בֵּיתֶךָ וּבִשְׁעָרֶיךָ׃

And thou shalt love the LORD thy God with all thy heart, and with all thy soul, and with all thy might. And these words, which I command thee this day, shall be upon thy heart; and thou shalt teach them diligently unto thy children, and shalt talk of them when thou sittest in thy house, and when thou walkest by the way, and when thou liest down, and when thou risest up. And thou shalt bind them for a sign upon thy hand, and they shall be for frontlets between thine eyes. And thou shalt write them upon the door-posts of thy house, and upon thy gates.

**Hebrew:** Unicode/XML Leningrad Codex (UXLC) UXLC 2.6 (file dated 19 Oct 2026) · licence: Public Domain / copy without restriction (tanach.us/License.html). **English:** JPS 1917 (The Holy Scriptures: A New Translation) (Public Domain). Status: verified · **not proofread** · https://alef.example.org/#/read/vahavta-full

## Shema and V'ahavta (Deut 6:4-9) Deuteronomy 6:4-9

שְׁמַע יִשְׂרָאֵל יְהוָה אֱלֹהֵינוּ יְהוָה אֶחָד׃

וְאָהַבְתָּ אֵת יְהוָה אֱלֹהֶיךָ בְּכָל־לְבָבְךָ וּבְכָל־נַפְשְׁךָ וּבְכָל־מְאֹדֶךָ׃

וְהָיוּ הַדְּבָרִים הָאֵלֶּה אֲשֶׁר אָנֹכִי מְצַוְּךָ הַיּוֹם עַל־לְבָבֶךָ׃

וְשִׁנַּנְתָּם לְבָנֶיךָ וְדִבַּרְתָּ בָּם בְּשִׁבְתְּךָ בְּבֵיתֶךָ וּבְלֶכְתְּךָ בַדֶּרֶךְ וּבְשָׁכְבְּךָ וּבְקוּמֶךָ׃

וּקְשַׁרְתָּם לְאוֹת עַל־יָדֶךָ וְהָיוּ לְטֹטָפֹת בֵּין עֵינֶיךָ׃

וּכְתַבְתָּם עַל־מְזוּזוֹת בֵּיתֶךָ וּבִשְׁעָרֶיךָ׃

HEAR, O ISRAEL: THE LORD OUR GOD, THE LORD IS ONE. And thou shalt love the LORD thy God with all thy heart, and with all thy soul, and with all thy might. And these words, which I command thee this day, shall be upon thy heart; and thou shalt teach them diligently unto thy children, and shalt talk of them when thou sittest in thy house, and when thou walkest by the way, and when thou liest down, and when thou risest up. And thou shalt bind them for a sign upon thy hand, and they shall be for frontlets between thine eyes. And thou shalt write them upon the door-posts of thy house, and upon thy gates.

**Hebrew:** Unicode/XML Leningrad Codex (UXLC) UXLC 2.6 (file dated 19 Oct 2026) · licence: Public Domain / copy without restriction (tanach.us/License.html). **English:** JPS 1917 (The Holy Scriptures: A New Translation) (Public Domain). Status: verified · **not proofread** · https://alef.example.org/#/read/shema-vahavta

## Baruch shem (said after Shema line) Siddur: Baruch shem kevod malchuto

בָּרוּךְ שֵׁם כְּבוֹד מַלְכוּתוֹ לְעוֹלָם וָעֶד׃

Blessed is the name of the glory of his kingship for ever and ever.

**Hebrew:** The Metsudah siddur, 1981 via Sefaria: Siddur Ashkenaz, Weekday, Shacharit, Blessings of the Shema, Shema · licence: CC-BY. **English:** original-gloss (original (project-owned)). Status: verified · **not proofread** · https://alef.example.org/#/read/shema-2

## Blessing formula (Baruch atah Adonai Eloheinu Melech ha'olam) Siddur: blessing formula

בָּרוּךְ אַתָּה יְהוָה אֱלֹהֵינוּ מֶלֶךְ הָעוֹלָם

Blessed are you, LORD our God, king of the world,

**Hebrew:** Shaliehsaboo Edition via Sefaria: Siddur Edot HaMizrach, Shabbat Evening, First Meal · licence: CC0. **English:** original-gloss (original (project-owned)). Status: verified · **not proofread** · https://alef.example.org/#/read/bless-formula-1

## Mah Tovu (first verse) Numbers 24:5

מַה־טֹּבוּ אֹהָלֶיךָ יַעֲקֹב מִשְׁכְּנֹתֶיךָ יִשְׂרָאֵל׃

How goodly are thy tents, O Jacob, Thy dwellings, O Israel!

**Hebrew:** Unicode/XML Leningrad Codex (UXLC) UXLC 2.6 (file dated 19 Oct 2026) · licence: Public Domain / copy without restriction (tanach.us/License.html). **English:** JPS 1917 (The Holy Scriptures: A New Translation) (Public Domain). Status: verified · **not proofread** · https://alef.example.org/#/read/mah-tovu-1

## Mi Chamocha Exodus 15:11

מִי־כָמֹכָה בָּאֵלִם יְהוָה מִי כָּמֹכָה נֶאְדָּר בַּקֹּדֶשׁ נוֹרָא תְהִלֹּת עֹשֵׂה פֶלֶא:

Who is like unto Thee, O LORD, among the mighty? Who is like unto Thee, glorious in holiness, Fearful in praises, doing wonders?

**Hebrew:** Unicode/XML Leningrad Codex (UXLC) UXLC 2.6 (file dated 19 Oct 2026) · licence: Public Domain / copy without restriction (tanach.us/License.html). **English:** JPS 1917 (The Holy Scriptures: A New Translation) (Public Domain). Status: verified · **not proofread** · https://alef.example.org/#/read/mi-chamocha-1

## El na refa na lah (Moses' prayer for healing) Numbers 12:13 (second half)

אֵל נָא רְפָא נָא לָהּ:

God, please, heal her, please.

**Hebrew:** Unicode/XML Leningrad Codex (UXLC) UXLC 2.6 (file dated 19 Oct 2026) · licence: Public Domain / copy without restriction (tanach.us/License.html). **English:** original-gloss (original (project-owned)). Status: verified · **not proofread** · https://alef.example.org/#/read/num-12-13

## Kiddush (Shabbat verses) Genesis 2:1-3

וַיְכֻלּוּ הַשָּׁמַיִם וְהָאָרֶץ וְכָל־צְבָאָם:

וַיְכַל אֱלֹהִים בַּיּוֹם הַשְּׁבִיעִי מְלַאכְתּוֹ אֲשֶׁר עָשָׂה וַיִּשְׁבֹּת בַּיּוֹם הַשְּׁבִיעִי מִכָּל־מְלַאכְתּוֹ אֲשֶׁר עָשָׂה:

וַיְבָרֶךְ אֱלֹהִים אֶת־יוֹם הַשְּׁבִיעִי וַיְקַדֵּשׁ אֹתוֹ כִּי בוֹ שָׁבַת מִכָּל־מְלַאכְתּוֹ אֲשֶׁר־בָּרָא אֱלֹהִים לַעֲשׂוֹת:

And the heaven and the earth were finished, and all the host of them. And on the seventh day God finished His work which He had made; and He rested on the seventh day from all His work which He had made. And God blessed the seventh day, and hallowed it; because that in it He rested from all His work which God in creating had made.

**Hebrew:** Unicode/XML Leningrad Codex (UXLC) UXLC 2.6 (file dated 19 Oct 2026) · licence: Public Domain / copy without restriction (tanach.us/License.html). **English:** JPS 1917 (The Holy Scriptures: A New Translation) (Public Domain). Status: verified · **not proofread** · https://alef.example.org/#/read/kiddush-gen-2-1-3

## Blessing over wine Siddur: blessing over wine

בָּרוּךְ אַתָּה יְהוָה אֱלֹהֵינוּ מֶלֶךְ הָעוֹלָם בּוֹרֵא פְּרִי הַגָּפֶן:

Blessed are you, LORD our God, king of the world, who creates the fruit of the vine.

**Hebrew:** Torat Emet 357 via Sefaria: Siddur Sefard, Birchat HaMazon, Blessing on Foods · licence: Public Domain. **English:** original-gloss (original (project-owned)). Status: verified · **not proofread** · https://alef.example.org/#/read/kiddush-wine-1

## HaMotzi (blessing over bread) Siddur: HaMotzi

בָּרוּךְ אַתָּה יְהוָה אֱלֹהֵינוּ מֶלֶךְ הָעוֹלָם הַמּוֹצִיא לֶחֶם מִן הָאָרֶץ׃

Blessed are you, LORD our God, king of the world, who brings forth bread from the earth.

**Hebrew:** Shaliehsaboo Edition via Sefaria: Siddur Edot HaMizrach, Shabbat Evening, First Meal · licence: CC0. **English:** original-gloss (original (project-owned)). Status: verified · **not proofread** · https://alef.example.org/#/read/hamotzi

## Shabbat candle blessing Siddur: Shabbat candle blessing

בָּרוּךְ אַתָּה יְהוָה אֱלֹהֵינוּ מֶלֶךְ הָעוֹלָם אֲשֶׁר קִדְּשָׁנוּ בְּמִצְוֹתָיו וְצִוָּנוּ לְהַדְלִיק נֵר שֶׁל שַׁבָּת׃

Blessed are you, LORD our God, king of the world, who made us holy with his commandments and commanded us to light the lamp of Shabbat.

**Hebrew:** Torat Emet 357 via Sefaria: Siddur Sefard, Shabbat Candle Lighting · licence: Public Domain. **English:** original-gloss (original (project-owned)). Status: verified · **not proofread** · https://alef.example.org/#/read/candle-shabbat

## Torah blessing (before reading/study) Siddur: Torah blessing (asher bachar banu)

בָּרוּךְ אַתָּה יְהוָה אֱלֹהֵינוּ מֶלֶךְ הָעוֹלָם אֲשֶׁר בָּחַר בָּנוּ מִכָּל־הָעַמִּים וְנָתַן לָנוּ אֶת־תּוֹרָתוֹ

בָּרוּךְ אַתָּה יְהוָה נוֹתֵן הַתּוֹרָה׃

Blessed are you, LORD our God, king of the world, who chose us from all the peoples and gave us his Torah.
Blessed are you, LORD, giver of the Torah.

**Hebrew:** Shaliehsaboo Edition via Sefaria: Siddur Edot HaMizrach, Preparatory Prayers, Torah Blessings · licence: CC0. **English:** original-gloss (original (project-owned)). Status: verified · **not proofread** · https://alef.example.org/#/read/torah-bless-1

## Barchu (call to the Torah blessing) Siddur: Barchu before the Torah reading

בָּרְכוּ אֶת יְהוָה הַמְבֹרָךְ׃

בָּרוּךְ יְהוָה הַמְבֹרָךְ לְעוֹלָם וָעֶד׃

Bless the LORD, the blessed one. Blessed is the LORD, the blessed one, for ever and ever.

**Hebrew:** The Metsudah siddur, 1981 via Sefaria: Siddur Ashkenaz, Weekday, Shacharit, Torah Reading, Reading from Sefer, Birkat HaTorah · licence: CC-BY. **English:** original-gloss (original (project-owned)). Status: verified · **not proofread** · https://alef.example.org/#/read/torah-barchu

## Torah blessing (after reading) Siddur: Torah blessing after the reading

בָּרוּךְ אַתָּה יְהוָה אֱלֹהֵינוּ מֶלֶךְ הָעוֹלָם אֲשֶׁר נָתַן לָנוּ תּוֹרַת אֱמֶת וְחַיֵּי עוֹלָם נָטַע בְּתוֹכֵנוּ:

בָּרוּךְ אַתָּה יְהוָה נוֹתֵן הַתּוֹרָה:

Blessed are you, LORD our God, king of the world, who gave us a Torah of truth and planted eternal life in our midst. Blessed are you, LORD, giver of the Torah.

**Hebrew:** The Metsudah siddur, 1981 via Sefaria: Siddur Ashkenaz, Weekday, Shacharit, Torah Reading, Reading from Sefer, Birkat HaTorah · licence: CC-BY. **English:** original-gloss (original (project-owned)). Status: verified · **not proofread** · https://alef.example.org/#/read/torah-bless-2

## Amidah preface: open my lips Psalm 51:17 (Amidah preface)

אֲדֹנָי שְׂפָתַי תִּפְתָּח וּפִי יַגִּיד תְּהִלָּתֶךָ:

My Lord, open my lips, and my mouth will declare your praise.

**Hebrew:** Shaliehsaboo Edition via Sefaria: Siddur Edot HaMizrach, Weekday Shacharit, Amida · licence: CC0. **English:** original-gloss (original (project-owned)). Status: verified · **not proofread** · https://alef.example.org/#/read/amidah-lips

## Amidah opening (Avot) Siddur: Amidah, first blessing (Avot)

בָּרוּךְ אַתָּה יְהוָה אֱלֹהֵינוּ וֵאלֹהֵי אֲבוֹתֵינוּ אֱלֹהֵי אַבְרָהָם אֱלֹהֵי יִצְחָק וֵאלֹהֵי יַעֲקֹב הָאֵל הַגָּדוֹל הַגִּבּוֹר וְהַנּוֹרָא אֵל עֶלְיוֹן גּוֹמֵל חֲסָדִים טוֹבִים קוֹנֵה הַכֹּל וְזוֹכֵר חַסְדֵי אָבוֹת וּמֵבִיא גּוֹאֵל לִבְנֵי בְנֵיהֶם לְמַעַן שְׁמוֹ בְּאַהֲבָה: מֶלֶךְ עוֹזֵר וּמוֹשִׁיעַ וּמָגֵן:

Blessed are you, LORD our God and God of our ancestors, God of Abraham, God of Isaac and God of Jacob; the great, mighty and awesome God, God Most High, who bestows loving-kindnesses, creates all things, remembers the kindnesses of the ancestors, and brings a redeemer to their children's children for the sake of his name, in love. King, helper, saviour and shield.

**Hebrew:** Shaliehsaboo Edition via Sefaria: Siddur Edot HaMizrach, Weekday Shacharit, Amida · licence: CC0. **English:** original-gloss (original (project-owned)). Status: verified · **not proofread** · https://alef.example.org/#/read/avot-1

## Aleinu, first paragraph Siddur: Aleinu (first paragraph)

עָלֵינוּ לְשַׁבֵּחַ לַאֲדוֹן הַכֹּל לָתֵת גְּדֻלָּה לְיוֹצֵר בְּרֵאשִׁית שֶׁלֹּא עָשָׂנוּ כְּגוֹיֵי הָאֲרָצוֹת וְלֹא שָׂמָנוּ כְּמִשְׁפְּחוֹת הָאֲדָמָה שֶׁלֹּא שָׂם חֶלְקֵנוּ כָּהֶם וְגוֹרָלֵנוּ כְּכָל־הֲמוֹנָם שֶׁהֵם מִשְׁתַּחֲוִים לְהֶבֶל וָרִיק וּמִתְפַּלְלִים אֶל־אֵל לֹא יוֹשִׁיעַ וַאֲנַחְנוּ מִשְׁתַּחֲוִים לִפְנֵי מֶלֶךְ מַלְכֵי הַמְּלָכִים הַקָּדוֹשׁ בָּרוּךְ הוּא שֶׁהוּא נוֹטֶה שָׁמַיִם וְיוֹסֵד אָרֶץ וּמוֹשַׁב יְקָרוֹ בַּשָּׁמַיִם מִמַּעַל וּשְׁכִינַת עֻזּוֹ בְּגָבְהֵי מְרוֹמִים הוּא אֱלֹהֵינוּ וְאֵין עוֹד אַחֵר אֱמֶת מַלְכֵּנוּ וְאֶפֶס זוּלָתוֹ כַּכָּתוּב בַּתּוֹרָה וְיָדַעְתָּ הַיּוֹם וַהֲשֵׁבֹתָ אֶל־לְבָבֶךָ כִּי יְהוָה הוּא הָאֱלֹהִים בַּשָּׁמַיִם מִמַּעַל וְעַל־הָאָרֶץ מִתָּחַת אֵין עוֹד׃

It is our duty to praise the Master of all, to ascribe greatness to the Creator of the beginning: that he has not made us like the nations of the lands and has not placed us like the families of the earth, that he has not set our portion like theirs nor our lot like all their multitude. For they bow to vanity and emptiness and pray to a god who does not save; but we bow before the King of kings of kings, the Holy One, blessed be he, who stretches out the heavens and founds the earth, whose seat of glory is in the heavens above and the presence of his might in the loftiest heights. He is our God; there is no other. Truly he is our king; there is nothing besides him. As it is written in the Torah: "You shall know this day and take it to heart that the LORD is God, in the heavens above and on the earth beneath; there is no other."

**Hebrew:** Shaliehsaboo Edition via Sefaria: Siddur Edot HaMizrach, Weekday Shacharit, Alenu · licence: CC0. **English:** original-gloss (original (project-owned)). Status: verified · **not proofread** · https://alef.example.org/#/read/aleinu-1

## Modeh Ani (on waking) Siddur: Modeh Ani

מוֹדֶה אֲנִי לְפָנֶיךָ מֶלֶךְ חַי וְקַיָּם שֶׁהֶחֱזַרְתָּ בִּי נִשְׁמָתִי בְּחֶמְלָה רַבָּה אֱמוּנָתֶךָ׃

I give thanks before you, living and enduring king, that you have returned my soul to me in mercy; great is your faithfulness.

**Hebrew:** The Metsudah siddur, 1981 via Sefaria: Siddur Ashkenaz, Weekday, Shacharit, Preparatory Prayers, Modeh Ani · licence: CC-BY. **English:** original-gloss (original (project-owned)). Status: verified · **not proofread** · https://alef.example.org/#/read/modeh-ani-1

## Adon Olam Siddur: Adon Olam

אֲדוֹן עוֹלָם אֲשֶׁר מָלַךְ בְּטֶרֶם כָּל יְצִיר נִבְרָא:

לְעֵת נַעֲשָׂה בְחֶפְצוֹ כֹּל אֲזַי מֶלֶךְ שְׁמוֹ נִקְרָא:

וְאַחֲרֵי כִּכְלוֹת הַכֹּל לְבַדּוֹ יִמְלֹךְ נוֹרָא:

וְהוּא הָיָה וְהוּא הֹוֶה וְהוּא יִהְיֶה בְּתִפְאָרָה:

וְהוּא אֶחָד וְאֵין שֵׁנִי לְהַמְשִׁיל לוֹ לְהַחְבִּירָה:

בְּלִי רֵאשִׁית בְּלִי תַכְלִית וְלוֹ הָעֹז וְהַמִּשְׂרָה:

וְהוּא אֵלִי וְחַי גּוֹאֲלִי וְצוּר חֶבְלִי בְּעֵת צָרָה:

וְהוּא נִסִּי וּמָנוֹס לִי מָנָת כּוֹסִי בְּיוֹם אֶקְרָא:

בְּיָדוֹ אַפְקִיד רוּחִי בְּעֵת אִישַׁן וְאָעִירָה:

וְעִם רוּחִי גְּוִיָּתִי יְהוָה לִי וְלֹא אִירָא:

Lord of the world, who reigned before any form was created. At the time when all was made by his will, then "King" was his name proclaimed. And after all things have ended, he alone, the awesome one, will reign. And he was, and he is, and he will be, in glory. And he is one, and there is no second, to compare to him or to join with him. Without beginning, without end; to him belong the power and the dominion. And he is my God, and my living redeemer, and the rock of my portion in time of distress. And he is my banner and my refuge, the portion of my cup on the day I call. Into his hand I commit my spirit, when I sleep and when I wake. And with my spirit, my body too: the LORD is with me and I will not fear.

**Hebrew:** The Metsudah siddur, 1981 via Sefaria: Siddur Ashkenaz, Weekday, Shacharit, Preparatory Prayers, Adon Olam · licence: CC-BY.
**English:** original-gloss (original (project-owned)). Status: verified · **not proofread** · https://alef.example.org/#/read/adon-olam-1

## Mourner's Kaddish Siddur: Mourner's Kaddish

יִתְגַּדַּל וְיִתְקַדַּשׁ שְׁמֵהּ רַבָּא אָמֵן

בְּעָלְמָא דִּי־בְרָא כִרְעוּתֵהּ וְיַמְלִיךְ מַלְכוּתֵהּ בְּחַיֵּיכוֹן וּבְיוֹמֵיכוֹן וּבְחַיֵּי דְכָל־בֵּית יִשְׂרָאֵל

בַּעֲגָלָא וּבִזְמַן קָרִיב וְאִמְרוּ אָמֵן:

יְהֵא שְׁמֵהּ רַבָּא מְבָרַךְ לְעָלַם וּלְעָלְמֵי עָלְמַיָּא

יִתְבָּרַךְ וְיִשְׁתַּבַּח וְיִתְפָּאַר וְיִתְרוֹמַם וְיִתְנַשֵּׂא וְיִתְהַדַּר וְיִתְעַלֶּה וְיִתְהַלָּל שְׁמֵהּ דְקוּדְשָׁא

בְּרִיךְ הוּא

לְעֵלָּא מִן־כָּל־בִּרְכָתָא וְשִׁירָתָא תֻּשְׁבְּחָתָא וְנֶחֱמָתָא דַּאֲמִירָן בְּעָלְמָא וְאִמְרוּ אָמֵן:

יְהֵא שְׁלָמָא רַבָּא מִן־שְׁמַיָּא וְחַיִּים עָלֵינוּ וְעַל־כָּל־יִשְׂרָאֵל וְאִמְרוּ אָמֵן:

עוֹשֶׂה שָׁלוֹם בִּמְרוֹמָיו הוּא יַעֲשֶׂה שָׁלוֹם עָלֵינוּ וְעַל כָּל יִשְׂרָאֵל וְאִמְרוּ אָמֵן:

Magnified and sanctified be his great name. (Amen.) In the world that he created by his will; may he establish his kingdom in your lifetime and in your days and in the lifetime of all the house of Israel, speedily and soon; and say: Amen. May his great name be blessed for ever and for all eternities. Blessed, praised, glorified, exalted, extolled, honoured, raised and lauded be the name of the Holy One, blessed be he, beyond all the blessings and songs, praises and consolations that are uttered in the world; and say: Amen. May there be great peace from heaven, and life, for us and for all Israel; and say: Amen. He who makes peace in his high places, may he make peace for us and for all Israel; and say: Amen.

**Hebrew:** The Metsudah siddur, 1981 via Sefaria: Siddur Ashkenaz, Weekday, Shacharit, Concluding Prayers, Mourner's Kaddish · licence: CC-BY. **English:** original-gloss (original (project-owned)). Status: verified · **not proofread** · https://alef.example.org/#/read/kaddish-1

## Birkat Hamazon opener (HaZan et haolam) Siddur: Birkat Hamazon, first blessing (opening)

בָּרוּךְ אַתָּה יְהוָה אֱלֹהֵינוּ מֶלֶךְ הָעוֹלָם הַזָּן אֶת הָעוֹלָם כֻּלּוֹ בְּטוּבוֹ בְּחֵן בְּחֶסֶד וּבְרַחֲמִים

הוּא נוֹתֵן לֶחֶם לְכָל בָּשָׂר כִּי לְעוֹלָם חַסְדּוֹ:

Blessed are you, LORD our God, king of the world, who feeds the whole world, all of it, in his goodness, with grace, kindness and mercy. He gives bread to all flesh, for his kindness is for ever.

**Hebrew:** Torat Emet 357 via Sefaria: Siddur Sefard, Birchat HaMazon, Birchat HaMazon · licence: Public Domain. **English:** original-gloss (original (project-owned)). Status: verified · **not proofread** · https://alef.example.org/#/read/birkat-hamazon-1

# Survival Hebrew

204 phrases from data/corpus/phrasebook.json in 10 situations. Transliteration is the project's own rendering. **Every phrase is flagged "native-speaker-needed" in the data** (pointing and register); slang is tagged.

## Greetings (27)

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| שָׁלוֹם | **shalom** | hello / goodbye / peace<br>Works for both hello and goodbye. |
| הֵי | **hey** | hi slang<br>Very casual, borrowed from English. |
| בֹּקֶר טוֹב | **boker tov** | good morning |
| צָהֳרַיִם טוֹבִים | **tsohorayim tovim** | good afternoon<br>Said around midday. |
| עֶרֶב טוֹב | **erev tov** | good evening |
| לַיְלָה טוֹב | **layla tov** | good night |
| שַׁבָּת שָׁלוֹם | **shabbat shalom** | peaceful Sabbath (greeting from Friday afternoon to Saturday) |
| שָׁבוּעַ טוֹב | **shavua tov** | good week<br>Said after Shabbat ends, on Saturday night and Sunday. |
| חַג שָׂמֵחַ | **chag sameach** | happy holiday<br>Used on Jewish holidays. |
| שָׁנָה טוֹבָה | **shana tova** | happy new year (Rosh Hashana greeting) |
| מַה שְׁלוֹמְךָ? | **ma shlomcha?** | how are you?<br>Masculine singular; feminine below. |
| מָה נִשְׁמָע? | **ma nishma?** | what's up? (lit. what is heard?)<br>Same for everyone. |
| מָה קוֹרֶה? | **ma kore?** | what's happening? slang |
| הַכֹּל בְּסֵדֶר | **hakol beseder** | everything is OK |
| בְּסֵדֶר | **beseder** | OK / fine / alright |
| מְצֻיָּן | **metsuyan** | excellent<br>Often the answer to ma nishma. |
| לֹא רַע | **lo ra** | not bad |

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| כָּכָה כָּכָה | **kacha kacha** | so-so |
| נָעִים מְאֹד | **naim meod** | nice to meet you |
| לְהִתְרָאוֹת | **lehitra'ot** | see you (later) |
| יוֹם נָעִים | **yom naim** | have a nice day |
| בָּרוּךְ הַבָּא | **baruch haba** | welcome (to one person)<br>To a man; to a woman: brucha haba'a. |
| בְּרוּכִים הַבָּאִים | **brukhim haba'im** | welcome (to several people)<br>Plural; the feminine plural is brukhot haba'ot. |
| מַזָּל טוֹב | **mazal tov** | congratulations / good luck |
| בְּהַצְלָחָה | **behatslacha** | good luck / all the best |
| לִבְרִיאוּת | **livri'ut** | bless you (after a sneeze) / to your health |
| תִּשְׁמֹר עַל עַצְמְךָ | **tishmor al atsmecha** | take care of yourself<br>Masculine; feminine below. |

## Politeness (22)

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| תּוֹדָה | **toda** | thank you |
| תּוֹדָה רַבָּה | **toda raba** | thank you very much |
| בְּבַקָּשָׁה | **bevakasha** | please / you're welcome<br>Does double duty: please and you are welcome. |
| אֵין בְּעָיָה | **ein be'aya** | no problem |
| אֵין בַּעַד מָה | **ein ba'ad ma** | you're welcome (lit. nothing for what) formal |
| סְלִיחָה | **slicha** | excuse me / sorry<br>Used to get attention and to apologise. |
| אֲנִי מִצְטַעֵר | **ani mitsta'er** | I'm sorry<br>Masculine; feminine below. |
| כֵּן | **ken** | yes |
| לֹא | **lo** | no |

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| אוּלַי | **ulai** | maybe |
| בְּטַח | **betach** | sure / of course |
| סַבָּבָה | **sababa** | cool / great / fine by me slang<br>Very common slang, from Arabic. |
| יַאלְלָה | **yalla** | come on / let's go / OK then slang<br>From Arabic; ubiquitous. |
| וָואלָה | **wallah** | really? / wow / honestly slang<br>From Arabic; tone decides the meaning. |
| אַחִי | **achi** | my brother (bro) slang<br>Said to a man; to a woman friend people say achoti (my sister). |
| יוֹפִי | **yofi** | great / nice slang |
| חֲבָל עַל הַזְּמַן | **chaval al hazman** | awesome (lit. a waste of the time) slang<br>Idiom meaning amazing; do not translate literally. |
| מָה פִּתְאוֹם? | **ma pitom?** | no way! / what do you mean? slang<br>Strong disagreement. |
| דַּי | **dai** | enough / stop it |
| רֶגַע | **rega** | one moment |
| בְּעֶזְרַת הַשֵּׁם | **be'ezrat hashem** | God willing<br>Common among religious speakers. |
| יִהְיֶה בְּסֵדֶר | **yihye beseder** | it'll be OK |

## Fillers and slang (23)

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| אָז | **az** | so<br>Sentence opener. |
| נוּ | **nu** | well? / come on slang<br>From Yiddish; prods someone to continue or hurry. |
| טוֹב | **tov** | OK / well / good |
| נָכוֹן | **nachon** | right / correct |
| לֹא נָכוֹן | **lo nachon** | not right / wrong |
| בֶּאֱמֶת? | **be'emet?** | really? |

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| מַמָּשׁ | **mamash** | really / truly / very slang<br>Intensifier. |
| פְּשׁוּט | **pashut** | simply / just |
| סְתָם | **stam** | just (because) / for no reason slang |
| בְּעֶצֶם | **be'etsem** | actually / in fact |
| כְּלוֹמַר | **klomar** | that is / I mean formal |
| אֲבָל | **aval** | but |
| אֲנִי לֹא יוֹדֵעַ | **ani lo yode'a** | I don't know<br>Masculine; feminine below. |
| אֲנִי לֹא מֵבִין | **ani lo mevin** | I don't understand<br>Masculine; feminine below. |
| אֲנִי מֵבִין | **ani mevin** | I understand<br>Masculine; feminine below. |
| אַתָּה מְדַבֵּר אַנְגְּלִית? | **ata medaber anglit?** | do you speak English?<br>Addressed to a man; to a woman use at medaberet anglit. |
| אֲנִי לֹא מְדַבֵּר עִבְרִית טוֹב | **ani lo medaber ivrit tov** | I don't speak Hebrew well<br>Masculine speaker; feminine below. |
| אֶפְשָׁר לְדַבֵּר לְאַט? | **efshar ledaber le'at?** | can you speak slowly?<br>Efshar is invariable: no gender forms. |
| אֶפְשָׁר לַחֲזוֹר עַל זֶה? | **efshar lachazor al ze?** | can you repeat that? |
| מָה זֶה? | **ma ze?** | what is this? |
| מָה זֶה אוֹמֵר? | **ma ze omer?** | what does that mean? |
| אֵיךְ אוֹמְרִים ... בְּעִבְרִית? | **eich omrim ... be'ivrit?** | how do you say ... in Hebrew? |

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| אֶפְשָׁר לִכְתֹּב אֶת זֶה? | **efshar lichtov et ze?** | can you write that down? |

## Cafe and food (27)

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| שֻׁלְחָן לִשְׁנַיִם, בְּבַקָּשָׁה | **shulchan lishnayim, bevakasha** | a table for two, please |
| אֶפְשָׁר לִרְאוֹת אֶת הַתַּפְרִיט? | **efshar lir'ot et hatafrit?** | can I see the menu? |
| אֲנִי רוֹצֶה קָפֶה | **ani rotse kafe** | I would like a coffee<br>Masculine; feminine below. |
| קָפֶה הָפוּךְ | **kafe hafuch** | latte-style milky coffee (lit. upside-down coffee)<br>The standard Israeli milky coffee. |
| אֶסְפְּרֶסוֹ | **espresso** | espresso |
| קָפֶה שָׁחוֹר | **kafe shachor** | black coffee |
| קָפֶה עִם חָלָב | **kafe im chalav** | coffee with milk |
| תֵּה עִם נַעֲנָע | **te im na'ana** | tea with mint |
| מַיִם | **mayim** | water |
| מַיִם קָרִים, בְּבַקָּשָׁה | **mayim karim, bevakasha** | cold water, please |
| בִּירָה | **bira** | beer |
| יַיִן | **yayin** | wine |
| לְחַיִּים! | **lechayim!** | cheers! |
| אֶפְשָׁר לְהַזְמִין? | **efshar lehazmin?** | can I order? |
| אֶפְשָׁר עוֹד אֶחָד? | **efshar od echad?** | can I have another one?<br>Use achat for a feminine noun (e.g. a pita): od achat. |

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| חוּמוּס | **humus** | hummus |
| פָּלָאפֶל | **falafel** | falafel |
| שַׁקְשׁוּקָה | **shakshuka** | shakshuka (eggs poached in tomato sauce) |
| פִּיתָה | **pita** | pita bread |
| סָלָט | **salat** | salad |
| טָעִים מְאֹד | **taim meod** | very tasty |
| אֲנִי צִמְחוֹנִי | **ani tsimchoni** | I'm vegetarian<br>Masculine; feminine below. |
| אֲנִי טִבְעוֹנִי | **ani tiv'oni** | I'm vegan<br>Masculine; feminine below. |
| אֲנִי אָלֶרְגִּי לְ | **ani alergi le-** | I'm allergic to ...<br>Masculine; feminine below. |
| לֶאֱכֹל כָּאן אוֹ לָקַחַת? | **le'echol kan o lakachat?** | eat here or take away? |
| הַחֶשְׁבּוֹן, בְּבַקָּשָׁה | **hacheshbon, bevakasha** | the bill, please |
| אֶפְשָׁר לְשַׁלֵּם בְּכַרְטִיס? | **efshar leshalem bekartis?** | can I pay by card? |

## Shopping (20)

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| כַּמָּה זֶה עוֹלֶה? | **kama ze ole?** | how much does it cost? |
| מָה הַמְּחִיר? | **ma hamechir?** | what is the price? |
| זֶה יָקָר | **ze yakar** | it's expensive |
| זֶה זוֹל | **ze zol** | it's cheap |
| יֵשׁ הַנָּחָה? | **yesh hanacha?** | is there a discount? |

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| אֲנִי רַק מִסְתַּכֵּל | **ani rak mistakel** | I'm just looking<br>Masculine; feminine below. |
| אֶקַּח אֶת זֶה | **ekach et ze** | I'll take this |
| יֵשׁ לָכֶם ...? | **yesh lachem ...?** | do you have ...? |
| אֶפְשָׁר לִמְדֹּד? | **efshar limdod?** | can I try it on? |
| מָה הַמִּדָּה? | **ma hamida?** | what size? |
| יֵשׁ מִדָּה גְּדוֹלָה יוֹתֵר? | **yesh mida gdola yoter?** | is there a bigger size? |
| מְזֻמָּן | **mezuman** | cash |
| כַּרְטִיס אַשְׁרַאי | **kartis ashrai** | credit card |
| אֶפְשָׁר קַבָּלָה? | **efshar kabala?** | can I have a receipt? |
| אֶפְשָׁר שַׂקִּית? | **efshar sakit?** | can I have a bag? |
| פָּתוּחַ | **patuach** | open |
| סָגוּר | **sagur** | closed |
| מָתַי אַתֶּם סוֹגְרִים? | **matai atem sogrim?** | when do you close? |
| שֶׁקֶל | **shekel** | shekel (Israeli currency) |
| אֵיפֹה הַשֵּׁרוּתִים? | **eifo hasherutim?** | where is the restroom? |

## Taxi and transport (15)

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| אֲנִי צָרִיךְ מוֹנִית | **ani tsarich monit** | I need a taxi<br>Masculine; feminine below. |
| לְאָן? | **le'an?** | where to?<br>What the driver asks. |

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| לִשְׂדֵה הַתְּעוּפָה, בְּבַקָּשָׁה | **lisde hate'ufa, bevakasha** | to the airport, please |
| לַתַּחֲנָה הַמֶּרְכָּזִית | **latachana hamerkazit** | to the central station |
| לַמָּלוֹן | **lamalon** | to the hotel |
| לַכּוֹתֶל | **lakotel** | to the Western Wall |
| אֶפְשָׁר מוֹנֶה, בְּבַקָּשָׁה? | **efshar moneh, bevakasha?** | can you use the meter, please?<br>Asking for the meter is common practice. |
| כַּמָּה זֶה יַעֲלֶה? | **kama ze ya'ale?** | how much will it cost? |
| עֲצֹר כָּאן, בְּבַקָּשָׁה | **atsor kan, bevakasha** | stop here, please<br>Masculine singular; feminine: itsri kan. |
| אֵיפֹה תַּחֲנַת הָאוֹטוֹבּוּס? | **eifo tachanat ha'otobus?** | where is the bus stop? |
| אֵיזֶה אוֹטוֹבּוּס הוֹלֵךְ לְ...? | **eize otobus holech le...?** | which bus goes to ...? |
| מָתַי הָרַכֶּבֶת הַבָּאָה? | **matai harakevet haba'a?** | when is the next train? |
| כַּרְטִיס אֶחָד לְ..., בְּבַקָּשָׁה | **kartis echad le..., bevakasha** | one ticket to ..., please |
| הַאִם זֶה הָאוֹטוֹבּוּס לְ...? | **ha'im ze ha'otobus le...?** | is this the bus to ...? formal |
| הַנְּסִיעָה הָיְתָה נָעִימָה, תּוֹדָה | **hanesi'a hayta na'ima, toda** | it was a pleasant ride, thanks |

## Directions (20)

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| אֵיפֹה ...? | **eifo ...?** | where is ...? |
| אֵיךְ מַגִּיעִים לְ...? | **eich magi'im le...?** | how do you get to ...? |
| זֶה רָחוֹק? | **ze rachok?** | is it far? |
| זֶה קָרוֹב | **ze karov** | it's near |
| יָשָׁר | **yashar** | straight ahead |
| שְׂמֹאלָה | **smola** | left |
| יָמִינָה | **yamina** | right |
| לֵךְ יָשָׁר | **lech yashar** | go straight<br>To a man; to a woman: lechi yashar. |
| פְּנֵה שְׂמֹאלָה | **pne smola** | turn left<br>To a man; to a woman: pni smola. |
| פְּנֵה יָמִינָה | **pne yamina** | turn right<br>To a man; to a woman: pni yamina. |
| עַל יַד | **al yad** | next to |
| מוּל | **mul** | opposite |
| בַּפִּנָּה | **bapina** | on the corner |
| אֲנִי אָבוּד | **ani avud** | I'm lost<br>Masculine; feminine below. |
| אֶפְשָׁר לְהַרְאוֹת לִי עַל הַמַּפָּה? | **efshar lehar'ot li al hamapa?** | can you show me on the map? |
| כַּמָּה זְמַן זֶה לוֹקֵחַ? | **kama zman ze lokeach?** | how long does it take? |
| אֵיפֹה בֵּית הַחוֹלִים? | **eifo beit hacholim?** | where is the hospital? |

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| אֵיפֹה בֵּית הַמִּרְקַחַת? | **eifo beit hamirkachat?** | where is the pharmacy? |
| אֵיפֹה הַמָּלוֹן? | **eifo hamalon?** | where is the hotel? |
| אֵיפֹה הַתַּחֲנָה? | **eifo hatachana?** | where is the station? |

## Numbers (22)

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| אֶחָד | **echad** | one (1)<br>Masculine; feminine achat. Counting aloud uses feminine forms. |
| שְׁנַיִם | **shnayim** | two (2)<br>Masculine; feminine shtayim. |
| שְׁלוֹשָׁה | **shlosha** | three (3)<br>Masculine; feminine shalosh. |
| אַרְבָּעָה | **arba'a** | four (4)<br>Masculine; feminine arba. |
| חֲמִשָּׁה | **chamisha** | five (5)<br>Masculine; feminine chamesh. |
| שִׁשָּׁה | **shisha** | six (6)<br>Masculine; feminine shesh. |
| שִׁבְעָה | **shiv'a** | seven (7)<br>Masculine; feminine sheva. |
| שְׁמוֹנָה | **shmona** | eight (8)<br>Masculine; feminine shmone. |
| תִּשְׁעָה | **tish'a** | nine (9)<br>Masculine; feminine tesha. |
| עֲשָׂרָה | **asara** | ten (10)<br>Masculine; feminine eser. |
| עֶשְׂרִים | **esrim** | twenty (20) |
| שְׁלוֹשִׁים | **shloshim** | thirty (30) |
| חֲמִשִּׁים | **chamishim** | fifty (50) |
| מֵאָה | **me'a** | one hundred (100) |
| אֶלֶף | **elef** | one thousand (1000) |

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| מָה הַשָּׁעָה? | **ma hasha'a?** | what time is it? |
| הַשָּׁעָה שָׁלוֹשׁ | **hasha'a shalosh** | it's three o'clock<br>Hours use the feminine numbers. |
| חֲצִי | **chetsi** | half |
| רֶבַע | **reva** | quarter |
| הַיּוֹם | **hayom** | today |
| מָחָר | **machar** | tomorrow |
| אֶתְמוֹל | **etmol** | yesterday |

## Small talk (19)

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| מַה שִּׁמְךָ? | **ma shimcha?** | what's your name?<br>To a man; to a woman: ma shmech? |
| קוֹרְאִים לִי ... | **kor'im li ...** | my name is ... (lit. they call me ...) |
| מֵאֵיפֹה אַתָּה? | **me'eifo ata?** | where are you from?<br>To a man; to a woman: me'eifo at? |
| אֲנִי מִקָּנָדָה | **ani mikanada** | I'm from Canada<br>Same for men and women. |
| אֲנִי תַּיָּר | **ani tayar** | I'm a tourist<br>Masculine; feminine below. |
| זֹאת הַפַּעַם הָרִאשׁוֹנָה שֶׁלִּי בְּיִשְׂרָאֵל | **zot hapa'am harishona sheli beyisrael** | it's my first time in Israel |
| מָה אַתָּה עוֹשֶׂה? | **ma ata ose?** | what do you do (for work)?<br>To a man; to a woman: ma at osa? |
| בֶּן כַּמָּה אַתָּה? | **ben kama ata?** | how old are you? (lit. son of how much)<br>To a man; to a woman: bat kama at? |
| אֲנִי רָעֵב | **ani ra'ev** | I'm hungry<br>Masculine; feminine below. |
| אֲנִי צָמֵא | **ani tsame** | I'm thirsty<br>Masculine; feminine below. |

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| אֲנִי עָיֵף | **ani ayef** | I'm tired<br>Masculine; feminine below. |
| חַם לִי | **cham li** | I'm hot |
| קַר לִי | **kar li** | I'm cold |
| הַכֹּל בְּסֵדֶר אִתְּךָ? | **hakol beseder itcha?** | are you OK?<br>To a man; to a woman: itach. |
| תִּרְגַּע | **tirga** | chill / calm down slang<br>To a man; to a woman: tirgi (or tirga'i). |
| מָה הַמַּצָּב? | **ma hamatsav?** | how's it going? (lit. what's the situation) slang |
| אֵין מָה לַעֲשׂוֹת | **ein ma la'asot** | there's nothing to be done |
| חָבֵר | **chaver** | friend<br>Masculine; feminine chavera. |
| אֶתְגַּעְגֵּעַ אֵלַיִךְ | **etga'age'a elecha** | I'll miss you<br>To a man; to a woman: elaich. |

## Help (9)

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| עֶזְרָה! | **ezra!** | help! |
| אֲנִי צָרִיךְ רוֹפֵא | **ani tsarich rofe** | I need a doctor<br>Masculine; feminine below. |
| תִּקְרָא לַמִּשְׁטָרָה | **tikra lamishtara** | call the police<br>To a man; to a woman: tikri. |
| תִּקְרָא לְאַמְבּוּלַנְס | **tikra le'ambulans** | call an ambulance<br>To a man; to a woman: tikre'i. |
| אָבַד לִי הַדַּרְכּוֹן | **avad li hadarkon** | I lost my passport |
| אָבַד לִי הַטֶּלֶפוֹן | **avad li hatelefon** | I lost my phone |
| אֲנִי לֹא מַרְגִּישׁ טוֹב | **ani lo margish tov** | I don't feel well<br>Masculine; feminine below. |
| יֵשׁ לִי כְּאֵב רֹאשׁ | **yesh li ke'ev rosh** | I have a headache |
| אֶפְשָׁר לְהִשְׁתַּמֵּשׁ בַּטֶּלֶפוֹן שֶׁלְּךָ? | **efshar lehishtamesh batelefon shelcha?** | can I use your phone?<br>To a man; to a woman: shelach. |

# Index

## Letters


Alef א 7
Ayin ע 22
Bet / Vet ב 8
Chet ח 14
Dalet ד 10
Fe sofit ף 32
Gimel ג 9
He ה 11
Kaf / Khaf כ 17
Khaf sofit ך 29
Kof ק 25
Lamed ל 18
Mem מ 19
Mem sofit ם 30
Nun נ 20
Nun sofit ן 31
Pe / Fe פ 23
Resh ר 26
Samekh ס 21
Shin / Sin ש 27
Tav ת 28
Tet ט 15
Tsadi צ 24
Tsadi sofit ץ 33
Vav ו 12
Yod י 16
Zayin ז 13


## Vowels and marks


Chataf kamatz בֳ 40
Chataf patach בֲ 40
Chataf segol בֱ 40
Chirik בִ 39
Cholam בֹ 39
Dagesh בּ 40
Kamatz (kamatz gadol) בָ 39
Kubutz בֻ 39
Patach בַ 39
Segol בֶ 39
Shin dot שׁ 40
Shuruk בּוּ 39
Shva בְ 40
Sin dot שׂ 40
Tzere בֵ 39


## Prayers and verses


Adon Olam 52
Aleinu, first paragraph 51
Amidah opening (Avot) 50
Amidah preface: open my lips 50
Barchu (call to the Torah blessing) 49
Baruch shem (said after Shema line) 47
Birkat Hamazon opener (HaZan et haolam) 53
Blessing formula (Baruch atah Adonai Eloheinu Melech ha'olam) 47
Blessing over wine 48
El na refa na lah (Moses' prayer for healing) 48
HaMotzi (blessing over bread) 49
Kiddush (Shabbat verses) 48
Mah Tovu (first verse) 47
Mi Chamocha 48
Modeh Ani (on waking) 51
Mourner's Kaddish 53
Priestly Blessing, line 1 45
Priestly Blessing, line 2 45
Priestly Blessing, line 3 45
Shabbat candle blessing 49
Shema and V'ahavta (Deut 6:4-9) 47
Shema Yisrael 45
Torah blessing (after reading) 50
Torah blessing (before reading/study) 49
V'ahavta 46
V'ahavta, verse 1 45
V'ahavta, verses 2-3 46


## Survival phrases by situation


Greetings 54
Politeness 55
Fillers and slang 56
Cafe and food 58
Shopping 59
Taxi and transport 60
Directions 62
Numbers 63
Small talk 64
Help 65


## Topics


Pronunciation traditions 4
Syllable practice 41
Practice words 42
Priestly Blessing, word by word 44
Remember every letter (mnemonic cards) 34
How to use this book 3

# Colophon, sources and statuses

**Draft proof** generated by book/build.mjs; letters data: data/letters/letters.json. Hebrew print face: Noto Serif Hebrew; handwriting: Gveret Levin; fallback Frank Ruhl Libre (all SIL Open Font License 1.1; licence texts for all three are in assets/fonts/*-OFL.txt and docs/licenses/; the Noto Serif Hebrew text is byte-identical to google/fonts ofl/notoserifhebrew/OFL.txt, fetched 2026-11-03). QR codes made with segno (BSD-3).

**What is placeholder:** every illustration is a labelled placeholder (no AI images have been generated); audio recordings do not exist yet (the app falls back to a device voice); the opening prayer is a draft pending clergy review; prayer texts and the phrasebook are not proofread by native speakers; stroke data for handwriting is draft quality; the companion-app host alef.example.org is a placeholder domain.

## Text attributions (from the registry)

Hebrew text: Unicode/XML Leningrad Codex (UXLC) UXLC 2.6 (file dated 19 Oct 2026), Tanach.us Inc., West Redding, CT, USA (tanach.us; "may be viewed or copied without restriction"). Cantillation marks removed. Not the WLC. English: JPS 1917, public domain.

Hebrew text: The Metsudah siddur (Metsudah Publications, 1981), as digitised on Sefaria where it is labelled CC-BY. Attribute to Metsudah Publications and credit Sefaria as the source. THE LICENCE LABEL IS SEFARIA'S AND IS NOT INDEPENDENTLY VERIFIED. English: original literal gloss.

Hebrew text: Siddur Edot HaMizrach, "Shaliehsaboo Edition", from Sefaria where it is labelled CC0 (no attribution required; credit given as a courtesy). Label not independently verified. English: original literal gloss.

Hebrew text: Unicode/XML Leningrad Codex (UXLC) UXLC 2.6 (file dated 19 Oct 2026), Tanach.us Inc., West Redding, CT, USA (tanach.us; "may be viewed or copied without restriction"). Cantillation marks removed. Not the WLC. English: original literal gloss.

Hebrew text: Torat Emet 357 (toratemetfreeware.com), as digitised on Sefaria where it is labelled Public Domain. Label not independently verified. English: original literal gloss.

**Image credit line (use once real images replace placeholders):** Illustrations created with AI tools and edited by the author.